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**The Effect of User-Generated Content and Fear of Missing Out
on Gen Z's Trust and Online Purchases in Urban Egypt
(Applied on Instagram and TikTok Platforms)**

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1. Introduction

Generation Z, which was born in the 2000s, is the first generation fully dependent on digital technology and social media as sources of communication, entertainment, and education. Most of the time, this generation relies on online reviews when making purchasing decisions. (Wijaya et al., 2024) The internet and technology have created a new lifestyle for them and become an essential part of their lives.

Online reviews and feedback are user-generated content (UGC) that expresses honest opinions about products or services, both positive and negative. (Bahtar and Muda, 2016) Due to the rapid spread of this content and its strong impact, its reliance by marketers is high. (Demba et al., 2019) User-generated content (UGC) has a strong impact on consumers' trust (Alamyar and Kurniawati, 2024) and loyalty, resulting in online e-commerce. (Alamyar and Kurniawati, 2024) Also, user-generated content (UGC) is considered as word of mouth because it is a source of more transparency and trustworthiness for consumers than traditional advertising. (Alamyar and Kurniawati, 2024)

Generation Z has higher anxiety and stress levels than any other generation due to the wide range of information and sources they have access to; this is referred to as fear of missing out (FOMO). (Wijaya et al., 2024) Fear of missing out is a sense of worry about losing out on news, knowledge, or experiences that others may have. One of the forms of fear of missing out is to use social media platforms obsessively. (Tolba, 2024) It puts pressure on them to avoid feeling socially excluded. (Wijaya et al., 2024)

TikTok and Instagram are the most popular platforms among Generation Z. (Pew Research Center, 2022) Because of the huge amount of short-form review video content, it plays an important role in influencing customers' trust and online purchasing decisions. (Swanson, 2022; Demba et al., 2019) And the reason for the spread, increase in content, and reviews is that the fear of missing out began to emerge, influencing purchasing decisions. (Yen et al., 2021)

This study aims to explore the effect of user-generated content (UGC) and fear of missing out (FOMO) on Gen Z's trust and online purchases in urban Egypt. This study specifically applied on Instagram and TikTok platforms.

2. Literature Review

2.1 The Changing of Generations with the Development of Social Media

2.1.1 Generation Z and Social Networking Sites

“Generation Z grew up with the social web, is digitally focused and technology is their identity. They have an informal, individual, direct way of communicating, and socializing is a vital part of their lives. They are the most ethnically diverse and technologically advanced and are referred to as Gen Tech or Digital native. (Dangmei, 2016)

Gen Z teenagers use social networking sites more than others, and they also use more than one site at the same time, in order to be in constant communication. Facebook is considered the traditional leader among users of social networking sites, followed by Instagram, and then comes Tik Tok. Also, different generations prefer different methods of communication, whether on laptops or mobile phones. (Kusa-Zazikova, 2016)

Social networking sites have become an essential part of Gen Z's life, and they deserve the title of the original inhabitants of social networking sites, as most of their time and most of their daily life situations are shared with each other on social media sites, which creates a very strong relationship between Gen Z and those sites. The largest percentage of Gen Z people now own smart phones, and this percentage is constantly increasing, which increases this generation's dependence on social media. (Gayed, 2019)

Therefore, society's trust in social media platforms increases over time, which affects the increase in interaction and purchase intention in a positive way, especially if it is through social influencers who have a good reputation. (Nadlifatin, 2024)

Millennials differ from Gen Z with social media, as Gen Z tends more to sites that display the lifestyle of others, such as photos on Instagram and videos on Tik Tok, but Millennials ignore that and prefer to deal with traditional social media such as Facebook. (Wardani, 2024)

One of the biggest differences between Gen Z and Millennials is the way they receive and respond to advertisements on these social media sites. Gen Z are quick to interact on these platforms and are very influenced by them in their daily lives. They always make their lives in constant comparison with what they see on social media, but Millennials are the complete opposite of that, as they are not affected by what they see to the same extent. Rather, they deal with social media as something secondary and not essential in their lives. (Tiwary, 2025)

2.1.2 The Rise of E-commerce and TikTok Shopping among Gen Z

E-commerce is expanding every day in its spread, especially with live broadcast platforms such as Tik Tok, which increases the rates of use of Tik Tok globally, and this increases the challenges for marketers in attracting the customer, especially since we are talking about a customer from Gen Z who is exposed to a very large number of offers all the time, which means that despite the increase in opportunities and ease of access to them, the difficulty lies in that you are not the only one who can reach them. (Nadlifatin, 2024)

The Tik Tok platform is characterized by the presence of many influencers on it, which increases its ability to compete with other platforms, as you always find different fans for each influencer who follow him in their purchasing decisions. From this standpoint, marketers have begun to search for the category they target and then search for influencers to advertise through them, which greatly activates e-commerce. (Chamat, 2024)

2.2 User-Generated Content (UGC)

2.2.1 Types of User-generated content (UGC)

"User-generated content (UGC) encompasses a wide range of digital content created and shared by consumers, rather than by brands or professional content creators" (Alamyar & Kurniawati, 2024) Despite other traditional forms of media and marketing, user-generated content (UGC) is defined as any content created by users rather than paid experts and is mainly shared online. UGC focuses on its relatability and authenticity, giving actual insights and experiences from actual users. (Alamyar & Kurniawati, 2024) To differentiate user-generated content from traditional and professionally produced media, researchers have identified a set of core requirements that define the nature of UGC. According to Younis(2025), UGC must meet three requirements: it must be accessible to the public, involve some creative effort, and be created without professional practices.

User-generated content has increased in importance in the digital world, especially among younger generations that mostly rely on social media platforms for suggestions and information. According to earlier studies, UGC has a big impact on how younger customers view brands, trust, and their purchasing behaviors. Younger generations are greatly influenced by user-generated content, shaping their brand perceptions, trust levels, and purchasing habits. It is an essential component of social media tactics aimed at this target audience since it increases brand authenticity and trust while encouraging both purchase intentions and actual customer behaviors. (Younis, 2025)

Online reviews and ratings: User-generated content appears in different forms across digital platforms, reflecting the different ways consumers express their opinions, experiences, and evaluations of products and services in online environments. Reviews and ratings are the most common type of user-generated content. Includes detailed feedback provided by customers regarding their experience with specific products or services. They are usually found on e-commerce websites and social media platforms. Both good and negative qualities are frequently included in reviews. Aurellia (2020) claim that UGC made society more open by allowing people to create, distribute, and market their own content, turning them into "prosumers" who actively take part in content creation.

Social media content: like Facebook, Instagram, Twitter, and TikTok include posts, tweets, images, and videos. They also share their experience, opinion, and feedback about the products or services. The importance of social media is all about the ability to influence consumer perception. Since these posts are not from the brand itself but instead from actual users, they become more trusted and authentic compared to traditional advertising. According to Aurellia (2020), UGC is the safest and most honest option for them in terms of their preferences for the product they wanted since they believed that the company could trick them into purchasing the goods by using exaggerated product information and benefits.

Hashtag campaigns, user mentions, and influencer endorsements are common forms of social media UGC. (Alamyar & Kurniawati, 2024) This type of content has the ability to go viral, increasing brand awareness and engagement. As an example, a popular hashtag on Twitter might

generate public debates about a product and increase its visibility. This message has a specific impact on firms that target younger generations, especially Gen Z, who significantly rely on social proof and peer recommendations before making purchase decisions.

Blogs and forums: are places where people can post long-form information, such as comprehensive thoughts, in-depth reviews, and long conversations about products and services. (Hussain Alamyar, Kurniawati, 2024) It gives people space to write long stories or share their experience in an interesting way without being forced to watch or read, which helps readers comprehend a product or service better than brief social media posts do. From a consumer point of view, blogs and forums contribute to the information search and assessment stages of the purchasing process. It is hence demonstrated that consumers have the potential to influence other users' purchasing behavior and intentions on a very high level, which was not witnessed before. (Kiran & Vasantha, 2016)

For younger consumers, especially Generation Z, blogs and forums shared through social media or discovered via search engines complement short-form material by providing more extensive explanations that reinforce credibility and trustworthiness. Gen Z significantly values authenticity and prefers to trust content made by their peers more than traditional advertisements. (Rahman, 2025)

Visual content: such as images and videos posted by consumers represents products in real-life scenarios. (Alamyar, Kurniawati, 2024) This contains unboxing videos, tutorial videos, and images of products being used or worn. This type of content allows users to show their experiences with products or brands in a more engaging and emotionally appealing way. Visual UGC is particularly powerful since it attracts attention fast and presents information in a short and easily accessible style. Visual content is particularly compelling since it provides a physical impression of what the product looks and feels like, often influencing purchasing decisions more successfully than text alone. (Alamyar & Kurniawati, 2024)

Visual user-generated content plays a significant role in forming purchase intentions and brand perceptions, especially for younger generations like Gen Z, due to their passion for visually driven platforms like TikTok and Instagram. Previous research has shown that product-related UGC significantly helps customers understand and think about the product, which in turn results in the intention to purchase the product. (Febrianti & Usman, 2025)

2.2.2 Characteristics of User-generated content (UGC)

User-generated content is distinguished by various core characteristics that explain its huge influence on customer behavior, especially among Gen Z. One of the most important characteristics of UGC is authenticity. UGC is considered to be more authentic and trustworthy compared to traditional advertisements. This perception was linked to the unbiased and genuine nature of UGC, which originates from real individuals sharing their experiences. (Alamyar & Kurniawati, 2024) Since this type of content is made by end users rather than brands, it is often seen as genuine and a reflection of actual situations.

Another important characteristic of UGC is its credibility and trustworthiness. Exposure to user-generated content that matches with consumers' personal beliefs and social identity has been

found to improve trust in a brand. The motivation to create UGC is inspired by a desire to support others and share personal experiences. This active participation not only contributes to the wealth of UGC but also boosts trust and credibility within the community. (Alamyar & Kurniawati, 2024) UGC often comes from actual consumers who are perceived as more genuine and relatable than traditional advertising.

Consumer engagement and interactivity are also known from the characteristics of UGC. When a consumer interacts on social media and decides to comment, share, or respond to content, this creates a two-way communication and emotional connection between the customer and the brand. Gen Z is tech-savvy and active on social media, so high levels of engagement can show that they are interested in a brand and develop an emotional connection, which can affect their decision to purchase. (Rahmam, 2025)

Another core characteristic of UGC is the experiential aspect, by letting customers see how other people use the product and share their own experiences with it. For Gen Z, engaging with a brand's social media content is frequently the first step in creating a deeper emotional connection, which influences their decision to buy. (Rahman, 2025) The experiential value of user-generated content may be illustrated through the case of Koffee Kulture, where features such as unique packaging design and in-store vibes contributed to creating a memorable consumer experience. This experience was widely shared by customers on social media, leading to increased curiosity and engagement, as users actively sought information about the product and its design. Consequently, the shared experience had a major virality effect, proving how experiential cues.

Finally, the core characteristic of UGC: accessibility and openness. UGC is easy to access and widely shared across social media, especially TikTok and Instagram, allowing the consumers a way to compare evaluations, products, and experiences. UGC can be concluded as a type of digital content that has characteristics of sharing free information, user engagement, and openness. (Rahmam, 2025)

2.2.3 The Impact of User-generated content (UGC) on Consumer Behaviour

User-generated content has a significant influence on consumer behavior by shaping how consumers search for information, evaluate alternatives, and make purchasing decisions. As UGC reflects real customer experiences rather than brand-controlled messages, it plays a crucial role in minimizing uncertainty and raising confidence during the decision-making process. says that customer trust in brand interactions is based on the perception of a company's reliability and accountability, which aids in attracting consumers and fulfilling their demands. (Borshalina, Tjahjar, Febrita, Aulia, Putra & Zulmartiansyah, 2021)

Purchase intention is considered one of the most direct effects of UGC on consumer behavior. The level of influence alone may differ from consumer to consumer and based on the kind of product or service being searched. (Kiran & Vasantha, 2016) This happens more with younger consumers, who rely heavily on social media posts, visual content, and online reviews when

making purchasing decisions. Engagement with a brand on social media increases trust and commitment, leading to higher purchase intention .(Rahmam, 2025)

In addition, UGC influences consumers' attitudes toward brands by developing credibility and trust. Consumers build positive brand perception and favorable attitudes when they are exposed to relatable and authentic content. This develops emotional connection with the brand and drives engagement and repeat purchases.

2.2.4 The Impact of User-generated content (UGC) on Brand Value and Credibility

User-generated content plays a significant role in developing brand value by affecting how brands are perceived in terms of authenticity, reliability, and transparency. UGC represents authentic consumer experiences, which makes brands appear more personal and relatable, unlike brand-created messages.

One of the most significant impacts of UGC is the ability to improve brand credibility and trust. Previous studies indicate individuals' trust in certain brands grows when they are exposed to UGC that aligns with their personal beliefs and social identity. (Younis, 2025) This trust originates from the idea that UGC is less biased and less commercially focused than traditional advertising, making it a more trustworthy source of information.

By boosting trust and credibility, user-generated content contributes to the creation of brand loyalty and long-term consumer–brand relationships, which are crucial components of brand value in digital markets. A recent study evaluating the impact of UGC on brand equity indicated that exposure to user-generated content positively increases brand loyalty and perceived quality, which in turn moderates the relationship between UGC and purchase intention .(Yousry & Fahmy, 2024) Consumers are more likely to develop loyalty towards the brand when UGC is perceived as credible and authentic. Such loyalty shows a long-term relationship that adds directly to brand value by reinforcing good brand perceptions and boosting consumer engagement over time. (Yousry & Fahmy, 2024) For Gen Z, user-generated content plays a vital role in building brand value and credibility because they rely heavily on social proof and peer opinions when evaluating a brand or making a purchase decision.

2.2.5 The Impact of Social Media User-generated content (UGC) on Gen Z

Social media platforms have made the growth of user-generated content possible. As digital natives, Gen Z consumers actively engage with platforms such as Instagram and TikTok, which enable them to create and engage with content and interactive elements of social media platforms, encouraging conversation and community surrounding user-generated content. Consumers may experience an urge to purchase a trending product to maintain relevance or be a part of a large community. (Seppanen, 2025)

User-generated content strongly impacts Generation Z, due to its perceived authenticity and relatability, in contrast to traditional advertising. Compared to traditional marketing tactics, research reveals that user-generated content also enhances engagement and improves conversion rates. (Seppanen, 2025) As a result, UGC significantly affects brand perceptions and credibility among Gen Z consumers, building trust and encouraging deeper emotional interaction with

brands inside the social media environment.(Seppänen, 2025; Younis, n.d.; Alamyar & Kurniawati, 2024)

However, social media UGC plays a crucial role in influencing Gen Z purchase intention and behavioral response. According to Seppanen (2025), personalized advertising on different channels enhances the purchasing intentions of Generation Z by up to 40%. Gen Z is attracted to firms that can adapt their marketing content to match consumer demands. While brands can modify their content to match consumers' interests, the younger generation still considers peer recommendations as having a significant factor more than traditional advertising or brand-created content. (Seppanen, 2025)

2.3 Fear of Missing Out (FOMO)

2.3.1 Concept of Fear of missing out (FOMO)

The fear of missing out (FOMO) is a concept referring to a widespread psychological state resulting from anxiety about not participating in something that others are perceived to be involved in. This participation could be in valuable events, experiences, or social activities in which one is not a part. This feeling motivates and forms a strong drive to follow the activities of others and constantly try to stay connected through social media, hoping to remain informed of all developments and important information. On a biological level, it increases the activity of the amygdala, to the point that the brain interprets this as a threat to survival. This effect may lead to social exclusion. (Przybylski, 2013)

Considering modern technological advancements characterized by constant connectivity, social media users are exposed to idealized examples and situations of others' lives. These situations and examples are carefully selected to reinforce social comparisons, creating the impression that others are living better and more successful lives. This impression intensifies the fear of missing Out, driving users to increase their use of social media and spend longer periods of time on it. This increases their interaction rate to avoid feelings of social isolation. (Din, Singh, 2024)

The fear of missing out is linked to many negative psychological effects. This phenomenon is considered one of the negative aspects of social media, its dark side. Some studies link the fear of missing out to feelings of stress, anxiety, and sometimes loneliness, causing psychological pressures that lead to dissatisfaction, especially in younger age groups such as millennials and Gen Z. (Martins, 2025)

Theoretically, the fear of missing out stems from the fundamental human need to feel a sense of belonging and connection to a community. Individuals excluded from this community through interaction and the pursuit of shared experiences and information within their digital society experience this fear as a psychological response resulting from anxiety and stress about being cut off from surrounding social connections or important opportunities. (Tolba, 2024)

From a technological perspective, FOMO refers to "a persistent urge to monitor social media updates (notifications, comments, likes, and stories)," driven by a desire to avoid missing out on any relevant social content. This increases the negative and mental drive to stay constantly

connected, even at inconvenient times such as during lectures, meetings, or upon waking up. (Tolba, 2024)

FOMO on social media can be defined as "an impulsive urge or immediate desire to interact with others on these platforms and engage in activities." Some of these activities include chatting, sharing, following page updates, commenting on them, and replying to messages. (Tolba, 2024)

People who suffer from a fear of missing out become robotic, programmed to do things without considering the reason behind them. Therefore, they pursue every new thing in life, even if they don't need it, simply to satisfy their psychological desires and avoid social exclusion. (Martins, 2025)

2.3.2 Triggers of Fear of missing out (FOMO)

The design and features of social media platforms are the primary triggers of FOMO (fear of missing out), as stories that end within 24 hours, live streams, and time-limited offers are among the biggest triggers of this fear. For Jen Z, a "digital native," short videos like Instagram Reels and TikTok are among the strongest FOMO triggers. (Taher, hussey, 2025; He, 2025)

Users, especially those of a certain age, are more influenced by social media content than others, particularly content that portrays the lives of people in their own age group. This influence is most prevalent on two platforms: TikTok and Instagram. Users are heavily influenced by the experiences shared on TikTok and by lifestyle photos on Instagram. (Eval, 2025)

2.3.3 Characteristics of Fear of missing out (FOMO)

FOMO has several characteristics that distinguish it from general social anxiety. From a psychological perspective, individuals with FOMO often experience increased fear and anxiety about being ignored. They are constantly preoccupied with what others are doing and constantly compare themselves to peers and influencers. (Almamy, 2025)

Those affected by FOMO tend to experience increased anxiety, tension, feelings of inadequacy, and self-deprecation when they are offline, when they are not participating in events, purchasing products, or enjoying experiences that others enjoy. (Almamy, 2025)

The effects of FOMO are reflected in the unusual behaviors exhibited by those under its influence, such as repeatedly checking social media platforms, multitasking, and difficulty disconnecting from online activities, which increases their time spent on social media. (Din, Singh; Tolba 2024)

FOMO reduces an individual's overall productivity, whether societal or personal, as a result of being preoccupied with the lives and experiences of others, which may not align with their own personal lives, but which they do unconsciously. (Almamy, 2025)

Studies show that FOMO increases "compulsive use" of social media, leading to what is called social media burnout and increasing impulsive, unplanned purchases, especially regarding lifestyle and fast-moving fashion trends. (Din, Singh, 2024; Almamy 2025)

FOMO increases feelings of dissatisfaction, annoyance, and distress due to the addictive feeling it induces, making people constantly perceive themselves as inferior to others. FOMO increases

feelings of inferiority, thus increasing the psychological vulnerability of "digital natives," which affects all their life experiences. Marketers exploit FOMO by making customers feel scarce to increase demand for their products by using phrases like "limited stock". "The unique thing about Generation Z is that while Millennials grew up with social media, Generation Z grew up with video-first social media". (Richer, 2018; Surianto, 2024; DIgiday, 2019; Eval, 2025)

FOMO can be described as an emotional feeling that makes an individual feel frustrated and lack self-confidence, leading to dissatisfaction because they see others obtaining information or experiences that they do not, and this feeling leads to sadness and depression. (abl, 2016)

FOMO is a type of addiction that manipulates people's minds, making them excessively use social media. This significantly affects their real-life social relationships because they become trapped in the virtual world, leading to increased rates of depression and decreased self-esteem, which in turn reduces their productivity. (Khaled, 2022)

Based on the above, FOMO is considered a psychological factor that increases feelings of anxiety and fear of regret over missed opportunities, leading to impulsive behavior, especially among teenagers, as they are much more easily triggered by FOMO than others. (Valdiani, 2020)

2.4 Consumer Trust

2.4.1 Consumer Trust in Social Commerce Platforms

Consumer trust in social commerce platforms plays a crucial role in shaping online purchasing behaviour. As consumers are unable to physically evaluate products in digital environments, they rely heavily on the credibility of the platform and the information provided through it. Trust reduces uncertainty and perceived risk, making consumers more comfortable with completing online transactions. (Gefen et al, 2003)

Platforms such as Instagram and TikTok integrate social interaction with commercial activities, allowing consumers to engage with brands and other users simultaneously. Features like comments, likes, and direct messaging enable consumers to observe real-time interactions, which enhances transparency and increases trust. Research suggests that platforms that encourage open communication and visible engagement are more likely to gain consumer confidence. (Kim & Park, 2013) For Gen Z consumers in particular, trust in social commerce platforms is often influenced by emotional connection and social belonging rather than purely technical factors. (Djafarova & Rushworth, 2017)

2.4.2 Factors for Achieving Trust and Credibility

Several factors contribute to building trust and credibility within social commerce environments. One of the most significant factors is authenticity, particularly through content that reflects real consumer experiences rather than idealized brand messages. When consumers encounter honest opinions and real-life usage scenarios, they are more likely to trust the information and consider it reliable. (Cheung et al.,2008)

Transparency also plays a vital role in achieving credibility. Brands that clearly communicate product details, pricing, delivery information, and return policies tend to be perceived as more trustworthy. Transparency extends to how brands handle customer feedback, including negative comments. Research indicates that brands that respond openly and professionally to criticism enhance their credibility and strengthen consumer trust. (Hali, 2015)

Consistency in communication further supports trust development. Maintaining a consistent tone, visual identity, and message across different types of content helps consumers form stable perceptions of the brand. In contrast, inconsistent messaging may lead to confusion and scepticism. Overall, trust and credibility are achieved through a combination of authenticity, transparency, responsiveness, and consistency over time. (Morgan & Hunt, 1994)

To translate these abstract factors into actionable strategies, it is essential to shift the brand mindset from merely chasing vanity metrics (likes, high follower counts) to cultivating a genuine culture of authentic engagement. For instance, authenticity moves beyond perfect, high-production content to embracing visual realism, sometimes by showcasing products in real-life contexts that might include minor imperfections. This simple act tells the consumer, "This is real life, and our product is part of it," enhancing perceived honesty more effectively than a perfectly scripted advertisement. This humanization of the brand is critical. (Audrezet et al., 2018)

A vital aspect of responsiveness is how a brand handles customer critique. While a purely transactional approach might suggest hiding negative comments, a humanized, trust-building strategy as requires transparency. When criticism arises, the brand must publicly acknowledge the frustration, validate the customer's experience, and offer a transparent, public solution. This proactive approach transforms potential friction into a trust-building moment, demonstrating a commitment to the customer over maintaining an unrealistic, flawless facade. (Hajli, 2015)

2.4.3 Rules for Creating Trustworthy Content

Creating trustworthy content requires adherence to specific principles that prioritize honesty and consumer value. One of the key rules is avoiding exaggerated claims or misleading information. Overly promotional content may reduce credibility, particularly among younger consumers who are highly aware of marketing strategies and paid promotions. (Djafarova & Rushworth, 2017)

Visual realism is another important rule. Content that shows products in real-life situations, including imperfections, is often perceived as more authentic consumers tend to trust content that reflects everyday usage rather than highly edited or staged visuals. (Schallehn et al, 2014) This approach reduces skepticism and increases perceived reliability.

Engagement also contributes to content trustworthiness. Brands that actively interact with their audience by replying to comments, answering questions, and acknowledging feedback demonstrate attentiveness and care. Trustworthy content is not created through isolated campaigns but through continuous and consistent communication that reinforces reliability and credibility over time. (Kim & Park, 2013)

Beyond these core rules, creators must prioritize the quality and context of engagement over mere quantitative metrics. (De Veirman et al., 2017) While social proof is a strong predictor of trust, consumers are sophisticated and often recognize inauthentic engagement. For Gen Z, one authentic, detailed review from an established peer or a micro-influencer carries significantly more weight than ten thousand generic likes from anonymous accounts.

Therefore, the content creation process must incorporate a Trust Check before publication, ensuring every piece of communication adheres to ethical and transparent standards. This check involves three key steps:

- The Flaw Check (Visual Realism): Does this content appear too perfect? If so, steps must be taken to add relatability, such as providing a "behind-the-scenes" context or showing the product in an everyday, non-staged environment. The goal is to convey honesty and minimize the appearance of manipulation.
- The Response Test (Transparency and Responsiveness): If a customer were to post a critical but fair comment on this piece, how would the brand respond? If the initial impulse is to hide the comment, the content itself may be too defensive or overly promotional. Trustworthy content anticipates and withstands fair criticism.
- The Value Proposition (Authenticity over Advertisement): Is the primary function of this content to sell a product, or is it offering genuine value (entertainment, information,)? Content should strive for an approximate 80/20 split, favouring value-driven content to build rapport before making a promotional ask.

Adopting this framework ensures that content development is intrinsically linked to reliability and credibility. (Hajli, 2014)

2.4.4 Trust Predictors: Platform Design, Social Proof, and Seller Reputation

Several predictors influence consumer trust in social commerce, including platform design, social proof, and seller reputation. Platform design refers to the usability and visual structure of the platform. A well-designed interface with clear navigation, secure payment systems, and accessible information increases perceived reliability and reduces perceived risk (Gefen et al., 2003).

Social proof is another strong predictor of trust. Indicators such as likes, comments, shares, reviews, and follower count act as signals that influence consumer perceptions. High engagement levels are often interpreted as indicators of popularity and quality, encouraging consumers to trust the product or brand. This effect is particularly strong among Gen Z consumers, who rely heavily on peer opinions and social validation when making purchasing decisions. (Cialdini, 2009)

Seller reputation also plays a critical role in trust formation. Sellers who maintain positive reviews, demonstrate transparency, and consistently communicate with customers are more likely to gain consumer confidence. A strong reputation reduces uncertainty and increases

consumers' willingness to complete online purchases, even in competitive social commerce environments (Hajli, 2014).

When leveraging social proof, brands must consciously focus on the quality rather than the sheer quantity of engagement. For example, instead of focusing solely on the volume of five-star ratings, brands can build significant trust by transparently addressing and resolving lower-rated reviews. Consider a scenario where a customer leaves a three-star review mentioning slow delivery. The trust-building action is for the brand to publicly acknowledge the logistical issue, explain the corrective steps taken internally to prevent recurrence, and offer a concrete gesture to the customer. This demonstrates transparency and corporate responsibility, showing potential new customers that the company is accountable and responsive when challenges arise. This action aligns with the need for consistent and open communication, reinforcing the seller's positive reputation (Hajli, 2014).

Furthermore, the design of the consumer journey must be humanized. A well-designed platform is not just aesthetically pleasing; it is empathetically designed. This means providing highly accessible information, clear FAQs, and proactive communication regarding order status, effectively reducing the customer's perceived risk and reliance on repeated queries. The interface should feel supportive and secure, not merely functional, as this emotional reassurance directly contributes to perceived platform credibility. (McKnight et al., 2002)

2.4.5 Instagram Trust Builders (Stories, Reviews, Brand Content)

Instagram offers several features that contribute to building consumer trust in social commerce. One of the most effective tools is Instagram Stories, which allow brands to share temporary and behind-the-scenes content. This type of content increases transparency and helps humanize the brand, making it appear more approachable and authentic. (Patterson, 2018)

User reviews and tagged posts also function as important trust builders on Instagram. When users share their experiences and tag brands, they provide social proof that influences other consumers' perceptions. These peer-generated reviews are often perceived as more credible than traditional advertisements, as they reflect real experiences rather than paid promotions. (Cheung et al., 2008)

Additionally, consistent brand-generated content reinforces trust when it aligns with user-generated content. Brands that maintain honest communication, visual consistency, and active community engagement are more likely to gain long-term consumer trust. For Gen Z consumers, trust on Instagram is largely built through emotional connection, visual storytelling, and a sense of belonging within the brand's online community (Djafarova & Rushworth, 2017).

The successful deployment of Instagram features as trust builders relies on their authentic application. Instagram Stories, for example, should be used for genuine, unpolished 'day-in-the-life' content rather than highly edited mini-ads. This is where the brand's personality its "human

element" is allowed to surface, forging an emotional connection that transcends the transactional nature of e-commerce. (Audrezet et al., 2018)

Similarly, user reviews and tagged posts must be celebrated and actively engaged with. Instead of simply showcasing positive reviews, brands should actively interact with content that features customers detailing how the product solved a specific problem for them. This shifts the focus from "look what we're selling" to "look how this has helped people like you." This relationship-focused engagement reinforces the sense of belonging that is crucial for Gen Z consumers and transforms individual pieces of content into continuous trust narratives (Kim & Park, 2013).

Ultimately, building trust in social commerce is less of a technical challenge and more of a relationship challenge, requiring continuous commitment to honesty and community over isolated marketing campaigns. (Morgan & Hunt, 1994).

2.4.6 Sustaining Consumer Trust in Social Commerce

Having established the importance of authenticity and transparency in building consumer trust, the literature also emphasizes the challenge of sustaining trust over time in social commerce environments. Trust is not a static outcome but a dynamic and ongoing process that must be continuously reinforced through consistent brand behaviour and communication (Morgan & Hunt, 1994).

First, while platform design is a key trust predictor, algorithm changes (e.g., No changes to Instagram or TikTok feeds) can instantly reduce a brand's visibility and disrupt the established flow of communication. Brands must maintain trust by diversifying their engagement channels and actively building direct community channels (like email lists or exclusive groups) that they control. Relying solely on a volatile algorithm to deliver honest content is a high-risk strategy; true trust requires owning the relationship, not renting it from the platform owner. (Kaplan & Haenlein, 2010)

Second, the initial surge of social proof driven by influencer marketing is now facing influencer fatigue. Consumers, particularly Gen Z, are increasingly skeptical of paid endorsements, eroding the credibility of large-scale campaigns. To combat this, brands must pivot to collaborating with nano- and micro-influencers whose audiences perceive them as genuine peers. The strategy should focus on establishing long-term, deep partnerships that reflect genuine product usage, moving away from one-off, transactional sponsored posts. This sustained commitment to genuine advocacy reinforces credibility more powerfully than mass-reach campaigns. (De Veirman et al., 2017)

Finally, trust is instantly fragile in the face of ethical failures. A lapse in supply chain transparency, a data breach, or even an inappropriate social media post can dismantle years of painstaking relationship-building. Sustaining trust requires establishing clear internal ethical guidelines—a moral compass—that dictate not only how the brand interacts with customers but also how it manages its internal operations. Consumers are now buying into the brand's values as

much as its products. Therefore, accountability must be swift and sincere when failures occur, reinforcing the humanized commitment to integrity. (Hajli, 2014).

2.5 Gen Z's Online Purchasing Behaviour

2.5.1 Understanding Gen Z' s Digital Behaviour

Online purchasing made essential life for all the world easier, making it easier to choose any item or product far from shops or markets. Another thing is that it's easier to know more about any item or product you need or to identify your needs from a product or item. Based on customer or consumer decisions, it's time to meet their needs. People before technology made them shop from markets or stores or shops like a journey or road trip. People could bear all the time and effort to take purchasing decisions, but after technology, anything is possible now. All different thinking and decision-making can be done from a seat at home. The world is changing with technology and the birth of a new generation, the generation of technology, or Generation Z. This generation was born amidst the world's changes and developments, which have greatly benefited the entire world. This has led to a gradual openness towards technology and communication. Consequently, from birth, Gen Z's first way of understanding their surroundings has been through technology, observing and being influenced by it. (Solmon, 2020)

With the daily advancements in social communication, this has led to its significant impact and importance in managing daily life, from following news and purchasing products to navigating various systems and activities. Despite differing global perspectives on what is harmful and beneficial, and despite the openness to technology and social media and the content, marketing companies, and products they offer, the new generation continues to be influenced by them. Their acceptance of the diverse content produced by these platforms, based on personal preferences or the action scenes or comedy accompanying product advertisements, is a significant factor, especially for young people. The behavior of Generation Z when buying online is always based on previous experiences or, for example, the opinion of people that by comparing one product with another, they are trying to find the easiest way to know what this product itself is about, whether it is information about it, details about its manufacture, or how the product is presented. If companies display their product on social media, it will become clearer, more of Generation Z's trust will become more and more attached to them, and the sales, purchase rate, and trust in them will increase, but the most important thing is that among Generation Z, they are interested in the opinions of people who have used the product before—what do they think of it? or they watch more videos evaluating the product or reviewing the product that they share with each other on the Internet, and of course it must be a reliable and important source and have a high follow-up rate and high interaction in order to be very trustworthy, and its words are what are true. In the end, Generation Z is blinded by relying on the realistic result that brings them to the point of trust before they buy the product. (Kotler , Setiawan, 2017)

The ways the following gen z purchases items through platforms have an impact on the time they spend on social media, like Instagram and TikTok. These platforms are primary sources of information, short videos, and fast-paced content that captures their attention. They are a major and essential source of information, product sharing, and entertainment, a stark contrast to television screens in previous generations. Television now continues its role, but on a smaller screen for personal use.. (Torres et al, 2023)

Gen Z favors quick content and short videos that are concise, engaging, and captivating, leaving the viewer with a sense of accomplishment. The reason they prefer this quick content is their aversion to lengthy, tedious videos that take up too much time. In today's fast-paced world, driven by advanced technology that transports them to other events they want to see as quickly as possible, their intense desire to keep up with the ever-evolving technology is driving them. This new generation values the credibility of the content presented to them, especially through a logo or brand. This leads to strong engagement and makes them believe what they see, whether it's a product with an advertisement or a follower's interaction. This interaction reinforces, expands, or enhances the credibility of the product, advertisement, or content they watch repeatedly, consuming their entire day without interruption (Turner, 2025)

2.5.2 Incentives for Online Purchasing Decisions for Gen Z

Encouraging customers is crucial for being close to Generation Z in online shopping. Letting them discover company offers will greatly help those who want to buy a product that has a short advertisement on their mobile phone while scrolling. This is one of the things that most attracts Generation Z and makes them think twice about the content and the product. As I mentioned, the younger generation has a keen sense of price; competitive pricing, unmissable deals, or even free shipping are key factors encouraging them to buy online. Customer reviews and video reviews of products they've seen in movies or TV shows also play a crucial role. While these reviews measure a product's appeal, for the younger generation, they serve as tools to influence the market and push purchases. Their buying behavior is heavily influenced by technology and social media, increasing the likelihood of them making a purchase. Recommendations from social media influencers, or opinions expressed on these platforms in general, also play a significant role. But are their opinions genuine or exaggerated? Determinants of Impulsive Buying Behavior Among Consumers on Social Commerce Platforms: A Field Study on Generation Z in Egypt. (El-Sayed ,2025)

The biggest factor affecting the new generation is their psychological motivation, or their fear of missing out on the opportunity to buy the product. If they hear that these products are in limited quantities in the market, the new generation will be encouraged to buy. It's definitely an unmissable opportunity to be like everyone else in the world, and consequently. (Nasr et al, 2023)

They don't think much and decide quickly to buy. This leads them to a stage where they become like a toy in the hands of digital marketing. Of course, if they liked the product they bought, it also influences the new generation, making them more receptive because they know the brand,

company, or store they're buying from and its strength and quality after purchasing from it, as I mentioned. They see that it suits their comfort and interests greatly. Moreover, the data stored by the company, store, or brand encourages them to buy more and to buy as quickly as possible because the brand considers its customers as friends, and they are certainly happy that a brand, no matter how famous, is being talked about and that people's opinions about it have influenced them to keep customer data, including theirs. This has a very positive impact and strengthens their decision to buy. One of the biggest factors encouraging the new generation to shop online is the availability of electronic payment methods, such as mobile payments. These methods often involve storing bank details in apps, for example, and paying through them. This encourages them to buy anything, anytime, anywhere, since using cash doesn't negatively impact their purchasing decisions. Therefore, electronic payments encourage them to shop and browse more easily, as it makes the process more convenient for them as shoppers. (Daradinanti,Sari, 2025; Goyal, 2024)

Furthermore, companies and brands must expand their presence in the point of sale and online purchasing through electronic payment. This is very important and beneficial because Generation Z, as a sophisticated and modern generation, understands the value of electronic payment, how important it is, how supportive it is, how much it saves them, and how much they will need it. The role of electronic payment is very encouraging because you can buy the product without any problems, and offers and discounts can save a lot of money for many Generation Z customers. This, in turn, encourages the company, brand, or product to continue caring for its customers without being deterred by customer demand. In addition, there are companies that understand and appreciate the value of Generation Z through their technological advancements, which have disrupted the market and enhanced the status of Generation Z customers. (Daradinanti, Sari ,2025)

2.5.3 The Impact of Linking Them on Sale

The new generation has witnessed a significant and powerful evolution in its use of the internet, particularly in online shopping. This has transformed the relationship between consumers and companies. The new generation is the most frequent online shopper and the most active online user. Furthermore, there's a strong correlation between their behavior and the influence of social media influencers and content creators. This allows companies to reach their best selling points. Using brands or brand faces in review videos or influencer opinions reaches the new generation faster and more effectively because they prefer these brands and their products. This, in turn, allows companies to renew their relationship with buyers and consumers, who are, for example, the new generation. Messages, for instance, can revitalize companies' influence on consumers, demonstrating the reliable role of social media in transforming user interactions into tangible profits. If we link digital behavior with marketing incentives, we'll reach a point where we reduce Generation Z's interest in purchasing the product or the product itself. If Generation Z sees content that captures their attention, they'll prefer that the brand understands their lifestyle. (Saroyini , Putri ,2024)

This undoubtedly helps the brand and the customer, specifically Generation Z, to build a very strong buying and selling relationship (Bilgin, 2018). Furthermore, companies or brands can measure their customer's behavior very well. Therefore, a company that understands its customer feels confident about their order because the company analyzes their behavior and demands (Dwivedi et al., 2021). It has the expertise to utilize and access its digital statistics, see the interactions it receives, and determine the strength of which content is most effective. Then, it continues working on, for example, the offer or the content it released, to solidify its relationship with customers. What creates a strong link is when the company is active in understanding the generation that follows it most, the product they request most, and encourages them with offers or discounts, increasing their chances of buying more and more. The widespread and highly active presence of Generation Z on social media platforms makes them the most enthusiastic audience for companies and brands seeking to increase sales and promotion opportunities. (Verma , Sharma, 2021)

The more successful companies are in understanding Generation Z, the closer they become to buying products online, and the more their profits increase (Priporas et al., 2017) . Furthermore, companies must build their strategies to target this generation as their primary objective. To strengthen company success and achieve continuous development, or in other words, to bring Generation Z to a stage of excellent electronic and purchasing comfort, thus establishing the company's strength for its competitors and enabling them to easily reach the company without confusion—in other words, to avoid being compared to the rest of the competitors and to reach an excellent point in the strength of their commercial or digital relationships (Ozuem et al., 2021). The real strength of Generation Z, which connects them to online shopping, is that companies and brands study them well, understand them strongly, and deal with them on the same level of intellectual and electronic power towards online shopping, and with much greater development. (Prasanna , Priyank, 2024)

This helps them achieve their strategy effectively and leads them to a strong stage in promotion and sales. Access to products is easy for Generation Z nowadays; all means are available for them to receive the product, whether through home delivery or online payment (Hossain et al., 2020). All of this will help them, and electronics never cease to amaze the world. But what matters to Generation Z customers is that these companies are honest, that the people who review them are honest, and that their personal opinion of the product is genuine (Erkan & Evans, 2016) . Reaching Generation Z isn't just about selling online or distracting them with short videos or content. It's about building a lasting image in their minds, establishing a strong connection that reinforces your influence. This is crucial given their strong minds and the way the internet has shaped their lives. Many companies can strengthen their position by building relationships with this generation, making them feel they're not alone, and showing them that they are truly there for you. They need to be able to reach you easily, quickly, and as you request, and be transparent with them. He encourages them to do things that will benefit them in their lives and work, setting them on the right path without lies, deception, or a negative mental image that makes them feel

hopeless or prevents them from understanding the message they are meant to receive. (Lakho, Rashid, 2025)

2.6 Relationships among the Variables

2.6.1 Relationship among User-generated content (UGC), Fear of missing out (FOMO) and Trust

This study will try to demonstrate that attitude, under some circumstances, can influence the level of trust in a brand as suggested by some studies (Jung, Soohyun, & Soyoung, 2014). However, Cheung and to (2017) argue that in fact trust is what influences attitudes when technology is concerned. Consumers' attitudes towards online group buying directly impact website trust worthiness (Suki & Suki, 2017). Therefore, inferring from the literature and the empirical evidence abovementioned, the study hypothesizes that there is a positive relationship between attitude towards UGC use and brand trust. (Demba et al., 2019)

Additionally, one of the factors that makes UGC trusted is its transparency, which makes people say both positive and negative experiences about the product or service, making people more attracted to trust them and don't think that they could be lying. (Rajamma, 2019)

People trust (UGC) a lot because it feels truly genuine, like it's coming straight from real life without any fake polish. It seems spontaneous and natural, not something carefully planned or pushed by companies to sell products. This happens mainly because everyday people like regular customers, friends, or fans create UGC on their own, instead of professional marketers or advertisers doing it for a job. So UGC becomes influence so much more what people buy and recommend to others. (Petersson, Nilsen, 2025)

Besides FOMO (fear of missing out), tourist trust is one of the most important factors that really pushes people to make a decision about visiting a place. This kind of trust doesn't just happen by chance—it's closely linked to the "uses and gratifications theory" in communication studies. This theory explains that people actively choose media (like social media apps) to satisfy their personal needs and desires. One of the biggest motives is seeking reliable information to help with real-life choices, such as travel plans. (Kaya, 2020)

For tourists, this often means scrolling through social media for honest reviews, photos, videos, and stories shared by other travelers who have already been there. These user opinions feel more valuable because they come from everyday people facing the same situations, not polished ads from hotels or tour companies. In fact, studies show that consumers and travelers tend to trust opinions from regular users much more than official information provided by companies. Why? Company info often sounds like sales talk, full of hype and perfect promises, while real user reviews include both the good and the bad like. (Iqbal et al., 2025)

this study shows how UGC really builds trust in brands and also FOMO to push people toward decisions like buying products. So, attitudes toward UGC create that trust because it's honest and real made by everyday people sharing good and bad experiences, not by company ads. Plus, with

the uses and gratifications theory, tourists scroll social media for those genuine reviews to feel informed, trusting real users' way more than hype from businesses. (Kumar, 2025)

2.6.2 Relationship among User-generated (UGC), Fear of missing out (FOMO) and Online purchase

Social media brand communication plays a huge role in shaping how people decide to buy things online, it's like the main driver behind online shopping habits (Erkan & Evans, 2016). The study really stresses how two types of content work together to influence buyers: user-generated content (UGC), such as everyday reviews, photos, videos, and shares from real customers, and electronic word-of-mouth (eWOM), where people spread recommendations through likes, comments, and reposts. On the other side, there's firm-generated content (FGC) from the companies themselves, like official product descriptions, promotions, discounts, live demos, and branded stories. Both UGC and FGC are super important because they create a full picture for consumers scrolling through Instagram, TikTok, or Facebook (Appel et al., 2020). UGC feels authentic and trustworthy like seeing a friend's honest review of a new gadget saying "It works great but battery dies fast" which builds emotional connections and cuts through ad skepticism. FGC adds the professional touch with clear facts, high-quality images, and special deals that answer "What's the price? How does it work?" Together, they shape not just quick buying decisions but the whole brand experience, making people feel excited, informed, or loyal enough to hit "buy now". (Wijaya et al., 2024)

also in Indonesia, Instagram supercharges content marketing efforts. A major spotlight falls on user-generated content (UGC) created and shared directly by everyday consumers—which stands out as neutral and crucial in swaying people's online purchases, particularly for fashion items that demand careful thought and high buyer involvement. Yet, research on UGC's role in fashion buying decisions remains pretty scarce. So UGC elements that drive consumers especially Gen Z to rely on it when picking fashion buys. It involved 278 respondents as samples, with data crunched via SEM-PLS analysis using SmartPLS software to uncover how variables cause and affect each other. (Aurellia, 2020)

But FOMO has become a major focus in modern studies of consumer behavior it's everywhere in how we shop, scroll, and make choices today. This concept is still pretty new in research, but it captures that nervous feeling when people worry about missing out on important updates, events, or experiences shared by their social circle like seeing friends post about a hot new sale, a party, or a trending product you didn't know about. It's not just casual envy; FOMO drives compulsive checking of apps, impulse buys, and even brand loyalty as people rush to join in before it's "too late.", but the downsides are real and can hit hard. FOMO doesn't just affect shopping habits—it takes a toll on individuals' psychological well-being, sparking stress, anxiety, and low self-esteem from constant comparison. Mentally, it leads to poor sleep from late-night scrolling, decision fatigue from overload, and even addictive behaviors like non-stop notifications. For example, imagine seeing Instagram stories of everyone grabbing limited-edition sneakers; that leave you regretting the cost and feeling more isolated afterward. (Wijaya, 2024)

This whole thing shows how UGC, FOMO, and social media posts team up to push people into online buys like UGC from real users feels super honest and builds trust, while company adds the solid details to seal the deal. FOMO kicks in hard too, making us buy trendy fashion or gadgets just to not miss out, especially for Gen Z in places like Indonesia where Instagram rules shopping vibes. so, brands should lean into authentic UGC more but watch out for FOMO's stress side effects. (Wijaya et al., 2023)

2.6.3 Relationship between User-generated content (UGC), and Fear of missing out (FOMO)

Gen Z grew up completely immersed in this super-fast digital world, where everyone's always on their phones—tech isn't just a gadget, it's like their second skin, from TikTok scrolls to Snapchat stories every single day. This vibe kicked off tons of fresh trends, like UGC where normal people (not brands) drop honest reviews, funny videos, selfies with new outfits, or unfiltered product hauls that feel way more real than polished ads. (Lee, 2025)

But it also brought FOMO, that give worry feeling when you see your squad posting about epic sales, limited drops, parties, or viral challenges, and you are like, "Oh no, I'm missing out on all the fun!" This study zooms in on how UGC's trustworthy realness and FOMO's scary push Gen Z in Bandung buy things, spotlighting online buys from cool local startups. They surveyed 126 young folks, and the results hit hard both UGC and FOMO seriously crank up those "add to cart" clicks and checkout finishes. For startups, this is straight-up advice gold: Gen Z is going to be your huge customer wave soon, so lean into authentic user posts and FOMO hooks to grab customer before they bounce. (Wijaya, 2024)

In South Jakarta makes study about the relation between User-Generated Content (UGC), Fear of Missing Out (FOMO), and Scarcity Promotion on purchase decisions within the TikTok Shop application, using a case study of Generation Z students, Results show UGC, FOMO, and scarcity promotions together strongly influence purchases. But looking at each one alone, only UGC and scarcity promotions matter a lot FOMO doesn't have a big impact on buying in TikTok Shop. (Hazami, 2025)

2.6.4 Relationship between Trust and Online purchase

Trust is known as an important factor in the buyer-seller relationships and online purchase intention in electronic commerce (Jarvenpaa et al., 1998; Zhou et al., 2007; Naveed and Eddaoudi 2009; Yuliharsi et al. 2011; Swidi et al., 2012). In the context of e-commerce, trust includes the online consumer beliefs and expectancies of characteristics of the online seller (McKnight et al., 2002). Krauter (2002) identifies trust as the most significant long-term barrier for understanding the potential of e-commerce to consumers in online environment. People make important buying decisions based on their level of trust in the product, salesperson, and/or the company (Kim et al., 2008). Alternatively, trust can be defined as willingness of consumers to interpret the possibility of loss during shopping process, according to this definition, trust can be considered as a kind of behavioral intention too. (Gefen et al., 2003)

Also, online shopping is steadily winning over more internet users, but it's not fully there yet many people still hold back because of real worries like data theft, fake products, or tricky returns, which scare them away and lower their interest in buying online. This study nailed down the main factors that can actually boost online purchases and make people feel safe hitting "buy now." It built a complete model that maps out all the key influences on shopping intentions, drawing from three major theories: TRA (Theory of Reasoned Action), TPB (Theory of Planned Behavior), and TAM (Technology Acceptance Model). On top of that, it weaves in crucial elements like trust (believing the site won't feel that it is scam) and security (knowing your info is protected). (Meskaran et al., 2013)

On the other hand, there is a study that talks about how trust and online risks shape people's buying choices in social commerce (like shopping on Facebook or Instagram). It looks at how consumers decide to buy, what drives their intentions and attitudes toward social shopping, how perceived risks affect online buying plans, and how trust influences behavior on shopping sites (Yadav et al., 2013). The findings expand our understanding of what boosts attitudes and intentions for online purchases, the risks people feel when shopping or rebuying online, and how trust leads to actual buys. Few studies have excavated into decision making on social platforms, how feelings, intentions, and quick rewards push product purchases (Yadav et al., 2013). . This research fills that gap by linking purchase intentions, social commerce habits, trust, risks, and source credibility (like believable reviews). Results open doors for more work on psychological factors in social media engagement, price evaluations, risk types, repurchasing, and even if mobile payments spark impulse buys influenced by reviews. (Lazaroiu et al., 2020)

2.6.5 Relationship among User-generated content (UGC), Fear of missing out (FOMO), Trust and Online purchase

Real user posts, or UGC like honest reviews, unedited photos, quick videos, and personal stories from everyday shoppers, build super strong trust because they feel completely genuine and free from company make people to see themselves in those shares and think, "If it worked for them, it'll work for me," which wipes away fears of scams or bad quality when buying online. Then FOMO jumps in hard, that nervous rush when you scroll and see friends, influencers, or tons of strangers hyping limited-time deals, flash sales, or viral trends everyone's grabbing, making you panic like "I can't be the only one left out!" This fear amps up the trust from UGC even more, turning simple browsing into urgent action "add to cart" and checking out super-fast to join the crowd before stock runs out. Overall, UGC lays the trust foundation with its relatable realness, FOMO adds the high-pressure push, and together they skyrocket online purchases, especially on apps like Instagram Shops or TikTok where Gen Z scrolls endlessly. (Van Dat, 2025)

Also, FOMO layers on top, hitting with that jittery fear of missing viral deals or trends your circle's buzzing about, but it's the UGC trust that makes the panic lead straight to purchases. You trust the user stories enough to act fast "Everyone's loving it, stock's low, grab now!" rushing carts on TikTok or Instagram without second-guessing, UGC owns the trust game with its

honesty power, FOMO just speeds up the buy, powering huge online sales spikes among scrollers who crave that believable vibe first. (Van Dat, 2025)

3. Context

3.1 Gen Z Favorite Platforms

Generation Z are those who were born from 1997 to 2012 (Swanson, 2022). Gen Z grew up in the age of the technological revolution. Most of Gen Z were between 0 and 7 when Facebook first launched in 2004, during a time when the internet was available everywhere. Also, COVID 19 had a strong impact on increasing their reliance on social media and shaping their online purchasing behavior (Leko Šimić, et al, 2021). Since when has social media become an essential part of Gen Z's day, because they use it for everything, and it helps them in many daily tasks. (Pew Research Center, 2022)

Social media has become diverse, not just for entertainment such as Facebook and Instagram. There are many types: educational (like YouTube and TikTok), professional networking (such as LinkedIn), lifestyle inspirations (like Pinterest), and e-commerce and digital marketing (like Amazon). As a result, this created a positive impact by making their lives easier, but it also negatively affected their focus and the efficiency of their tasks (Tolba, 2024). There is much research that says that the focus of Gen Z has decreased from 12 seconds to only 8 seconds, and it continues to decline. (Swanson, 2022)

Previous studies have examined the strong attachment and dependence on social media by the younger generation is due to three important features, which are short-form content, quick responses, and instant interaction. Most platforms now rely on short content because it has become the favorite of the younger generation, such as reels and text on visuals. Quick responses are a very important feature and a main reason for their attachment to social media because they no longer need, like the older generations, to spend hours searching for the things they want—news, information, events, or even something to buy. Today everything is just a click away. And the instant interaction it is the characteristic that keeps them in touch and connected with others. Generation Z is known for its strong desire to express opinions on various topics and share personal updates; social media platforms provide them with the space to satisfy this need for immediate expression and sharing. (Swanson, 2022; Pew Research Center, 2022)

Due to the importance of social media, the business became interested in studying Gen Z's social media behavior in order to better understand their needs and target them correctly. One of the researchers found that the top 3 used platforms are YouTube (95%), TikTok (67%), and Instagram (62%). (Pew Research Center, 2022)

TikTok, Instagram, and YouTube are favorite platforms. They spend a lot of time on them (Swanson, 2022) due to the variety of content and interaction. TikTok popularity comes from the diversity of his short videos, which discuss many topics, such as product reviews. Instagram focuses on visual content (photos and reels); it meets their needs for self-expression that reflects

their lifestyle. YouTube is a favorite platform for long-form and educational content. So, they are the most preferred platform because they satisfy Gen Z needs for quick, engaging, and personal digital experiences. (Pew Research Center, 2022)

Previous studies have examined the influence of social media advertising on consumer purchasing behaviour. Businesses target them depending on the customers' needs. The same people who gather information about the product. Ads aim not only for awareness or engagement. Rather, the client completes the entire purchase through social media. (Ninan et al., 2020)

3.2 TikTok Content and Diversity

According to a book about Gen Z, it describes them as a generation aware of the power of their voice. A concept of social media, especially TikTok, which is clearly demonstrated by allowing them to create content about their opinions and go viral, reaching millions of views overnight (Swanson, 2022). TikTok is one of the most famous and important platforms globally that achieved great success in a short time, and this is due to its unique features. It is the first platform that relies on short videos, and because it attracted users' admiration, other platforms started to imitate it, like YouTube (shorts) and Instagram (reels). Not only that, but the videos also start with attention-grabbing elements, which in marketing are called hooks. Additionally, the variety of sounds and filters plays a significant role in people's attachment to TikTok. (Wang, 2024)

TikTok is one of the biggest platforms for entertainment, discovery, and social interaction. This is a result of the huge variety of its content. Including entertainment, educational, and daily life vlogs, as well as reviews from people who share their honest opinions and experiences about products they bought, it is now known as user-generated content. This led Generation Z to consider TikTok as a source of credibility. (Wang, 2024)

User-generated content and reviews are the most important factor in TikTok's success, as TikTok's algorithms are different from other platforms. The main page, the "For You" page, displays content based on user interests, not just people they follow like on Facebook and Instagram. It shows videos according to the user's interests, constantly studying user behaviour to show them videos similar to what they like. This means there is no difference among content depending on the number of followers; instead, it gives content an equal chance to appear based on the importance of the idea presented. (Baumann et al., 2025)

TikTok influences the customer's buying decisions and allows users to complete the whole purchase process in the app. Through collaborative commerce tools, collect information about the product and other user recommendations that encourage their purchasing decisions. That content attracts the customers and increases the purchasing process. TikTok marketing science research said that 47% of users buy a product after gathering information about the product on TikTok. (Pramesti, Alversia, 2024)

3.3 Instagram Content and Diversity

Instagram launched on 6 October 2010. By the end of 2014, its users reached more than 300. The app is described as a unique and enjoyable experience for sharing photos and videos about their lives with friends. They added that they favor it over Facebook content. (Bahtar, Muda, 2016) And as he relies on the images, quality of photos and videos is important because the app's algorithms favor high-quality content over poor-quality content.

Instagram's most important feature came out in 2016: stories. In contrast to the rest of the content, which is deleted after 24 hours, that type of content keeps the users attached due to its shortness. It began with 15 seconds. (Costa, 2022) and now it's 1 minute. 500 million users create stories and interact with others' stories every day (Costa, 2022) using sounds and filters. The stories allows users share personal photos with their friends and use the business page to share content with their customers, such as branch openings, limited-time offers, or experiences and opinions from other customers (UGC).

Unlike TikTok, Instagram's homepage shows users only the content of the people they follow and are interested in. This makes it easier for business accounts to reach people who are known to be interested and have the intention to purchase. They can create content that influences them based on where they are in the consumer decision journey. Also, reels have attracted significant attention from users. That's what TikTok and Instagram have in common: they both aim to improve with every update. This was evident in recent updates that made it easier for users to edit and included advanced features to enhance performance and win the competition. (Marwick, 2021)

Instagram has a unique composition of users because most of them are from Generation Z, who consider it their primary platform, as opposed to millennials, who consider Facebook their primary platform. (Pew Research Center, 2022) It is an opportunity platform for any business that wants to reach them and show them that it represents them. Most start-up businesses now begin with Instagram because it is easy to create visual content that build trust in it, attachment, and engagement among gen z shoppers. One of the most successful types of content recently has been storytelling. (Swanson, 2022)

3.4 TikTok vs Instagram

Previous research has examined the differences between TikTok and Instagram in terms of content placement, user interactions, and how marketers can use them to effectively reach Gen Z. TikTok algorithms primarily recommend content that the user is interested in and allow them to discover videos from accounts they do not follow, as opposed to Instagram algorithms, which prioritize content from accounts the user follows, making it easier for businesses to maintain customer relationships. TikTok encourages trending based on creative ideas, but Instagram encourages it based on the number of followers. (Swanson, 2022)

These differences highlight the importance of platform selection based on marketing objectives, as TikTok is more suitable for awareness or engagement, and Instagram is more suitable for building brand trust and strong, profitable relationships with customers.

4. Case Studies

4.1 TikTok

TikTok has an important feature that allows the brand to respond to customers' comments by posting videos to answer their questions. Enable direct communication. The question-and-answer type of content is used to enhance engagement and customer satisfaction. (Burhan et al., 2024)

In December 2024, many videos of negative reviews from Cilantro customers spread on TikTok, stating that they love the coffee quality but find the cup lid unsuitable and uncomfortable for them and that they want it changed. Instead of treating this feedback as negative word-of-mouth content in the form of a thread, Cilantro takes the opportunity and chooses to turn it into strength, showing that they are close to their customers, listening to their feedback, and thinking about their satisfaction.

TikTok was the platform they chose for achieving the campaign's goal. The brand posted a video with some of the reviews, and they announced the change to the flat lid at the end of the clip. After the announcement, users started creating videos for their morning coffee experiences, generating positive user-generated content (UGC).

4.2 Instagram

In 2023, an Egyptian brand, Oudies, emerged as a unique example of how social media, specifically Instagram, can help a business succeed and build customer loyalty even before its official launches. Ouda the brand founder announced on Instagram that he had decided to take on a challenge of starting a hoodie manufacturing business in 21 days, after sharing videos about the pricing strategies of local brands in Egypt. Followers began encouraging Ouda to create a brand that reflected the values he was advocating for. So he decided to make the challenge public content and document the entire journey through a series of vlogs on Instagram.

Instagram made it easy for Ouda to reach the target audiences, Gen Z, as he relied on Reels to create short-form videos (vlogs) and used a storytelling strategy. With this approach, he was able to create a community of people on Instagram who engaged and felt connected with the owners. (Swanson, 2022) His goal was to achieve customer satisfaction, so he shared with his social media followers the entire production process in details. He also asked followers for recommendations regarding source of materials, select colors, and the brand name using stories to involve customers in decisions making. (Kaplan & Haenlein, 2010)

People were very engaged with the content, and they were looking forward to seeing the end result. (Wang, 2024) They felt a strong attachment; some said that they would purchase the hoodies once they were available and believe in the brand, while others begun to offer free

services such as advertising and graphic design. The hoodies sold out in less than an hour after making them available on the website. The brand then started delivering orders to customers and encouraged them to take photos, to be content generated by user.

In conclusion, Oudie's success highlights the importance of understanding the target audience and ensuring an active presence on social media platforms. Through consistent interaction and effective use of Instagram features, the brand was able to build strong relationships with its audiences and earn their trust. (Sheldon & Bryant, 2016; Marwick, 2021)

5. Exploratory Study

5.1 The Study Details

In this study we made six interviews, The first was with Hatem Zazouu, The CEO and Founder of Foresight consulting. The second interview was with Nadine Zizo, Account manager in Cstudio, The Third one was with Alyaa EL-Qbany, A Marketing head in Kayan company. The fourth was with Passant Ahmed, A brand owner and founder of Shinelle. The fifth was with Hazem Maged, An Internal auditor in Etisalat Masr. The last was with Ahmed Alaa, A Marketing speacialist in Perfect Bite KSA. Half of the interviews were conducted via phone calls, The other half were face to face.

The six participants were selected for the interviews due to their different professional backgrounds and areas of expertise. This diversity allows the study to gather a range of perspectives that contribute to a more comprehensive understanding of the research topic. Each participant represents a specific field, and together their insights complement one another, enhancing the overall value of the exploratory research.

5.2 The Study Results

1. Question: In your opinion, why did companies start using UGC to affect the purchasing decision of Gen Z?

One of the experts said that the effect of user-generated content is so huge because it comes from the target audience themselves. So, it becomes so trusted. Also, another one said that the company starts using user-generated content when it becomes well-known and has a strong base. Because it doesn't increase sales but gives the company content that it can post as ads and stories to increase trust. In addition, another one said that user generated content is something that almost never ends. People always need to see it. For example, people always have a fear of buying, especially in online shopping. They wonder, will the product look the same in reality or not? Does the food actually taste good? Will the clothes look nice or not? Therefore, the idea of user-generated content is like reviews, feedback, or recommendations. It never stops. Its advertisements are always useful. And every brand should use it. It has a huge impact, especially because Gen Z is one of the groups most influenced by social media. We were born into social media, unlike millennials. For them, social media was something new. And not all of them understand it or use it as professionally as we do. Moreover, another one said we did advertising

and branding of Koffee Kulture. It was designed to target Gen Z. Then, people started posting viral cans and vibes. As a result, this content started to generate virality and fear of missing out. Finally, another one added that it helps the product reach Gen Z faster, no matter who they are. And companies start working with influencers from the same generation to influence their audience more effectively.

- User-generated content builds trust because it comes from real people, not brands. And when it goes viral, it increases credibility even more, especially for Gen Z. So, it's an important and strong element in modern marketing.

2. Question: What are the advantages and disadvantages of UGC?

About the advantages of using user-generated content: most experts said that user generated content creators are ordinary people, like one of your friends giving you a review or feedback. Also, some experts said that with a small cost, user-generated content can trigger a virality effect, and it can happen organically. Another expert mentioned that some startup brands create killer campaigns using user-generated content. In addition, one expert said that in the Egyptian market, the approach is mostly indirect, based on storytelling. On another note, one expert said that user-generated content doesn't tell you to buy, and Gen Z is used to hearing the word "BUY," so it doesn't become effective. On the other hand, regarding the disadvantages of user-generated content: half of the experts said that if you choose a creator who doesn't look like the target audience, it makes the brand less trusted. Another expert said that most of the time, user-generated content creators are not professional, so they create poor-quality content with an incorrect appearance. Another point was that user-generated content is safe for now, but it's only a matter of time before it becomes less trusted in the future. Furthermore, one expert said that bigger companies don't have the flexibility that startups have, and they are not willing to use this type of content. Finally, another expert said that the most important thing is that the content should be positive. If you want to promote a product well, positivity helps it reach people like Gen Z faster, makes them trust it, and encourages them to try it and overcome their doubts. On the negative side, some companies create illusions—like fake pages and fake followers—and start selling products that are useless or not as they were presented.

- User-generated content can be a double-edged sword because it's created by real people sharing their honest opinions. It's also low cost, helps content go viral, and works well with Gen Z. In Egypt, it's usually done in an indirect way. But if the wrong creator is chosen or the content quality is too low, it can harm trust. Overall, when used wisely, user-generated content is a powerful but sensitive tool.

3. Question: How can we deal with these disadvantages?

Half of the experts said that the company should review the videos before sharing, to make sure that they are not too professional but also have a good appearance. Another expert said to use user-generated content creators who look like the target audience. In addition, another one said

that in the future, they should make some changes in user-generated content to be more trusted for the new people's behavior. Finally, another one said that it all depends on the strategy of each company.

- Brands should review user-generated content before posting to keep it natural while still making sure it's high quality. It's also important to choose creators who reflect the target audience. In addition, user-generated content needs to adapt with future trends to match changes in audience behavior.

4. Question: What makes the UGC method more authentic and trusted than traditional advertising methods?

Some of the experts said that user-generated content comes from the target audience themselves, and they talk casually. They bought the product and shared their experience without a script, so it became so trustworthy. Another expert said that it should be simple and not overdone, to be close to the way Gen Z thinks and speaks, because they know when you want to sell and when you sell something that may not be true. Another one said that the result of everyone having a mobile phone in every home is different from traditional ads on TV screens. This creates a huge spread, makes the product well-known, and especially makes Gen Z interested in buying it.

- People trust user-generated content because it feels real. It comes from normal people sharing their own experiences. They don't just say positive things; they talk in a natural, unscripted way. This simplicity makes user-generated content very powerful, especially for Gen Z.

5. Question: What about the highly famous?

One of the experts said that no matter how famous influencers are, people have started to feel that they're doing it just for money, and that their advertisements are not always genuine. Also, many people have become more aware and can now tell the difference between honest content and paid content. This is why some companies choose to use non-famous people, to make customers feel more trusted. Another one said that the large number of followers doesn't matter if the goal is user-generated content, but it matters if the goal is to increase sales. Another expert said that it's okay to advertise your product with a famous person in any field, as long as they have a big influence, target Gen Z, and the ad reaches many people.

- If the person is very famous, the content starts to feel like an ad. But if they are not famous, it looks more genuine and natural.

6. Question: What is the difference between the effect of UGC on Gen Z and Millennials?

All of the experts said that the effect of user-generated content on millennials and Gen Z is different. For example, they couldn't persuade millennials to purchase like Gen Z, due to the difference in behaviors between them, and because Gen Z was born with social media and knows how to use it efficiently, so they're highly influenced by it. On the other hand, for millennials, social media is something new, and not all of them understand all its features. That's why UGC

has a stronger impact on Gen Z. Another one said that millennials require more traditional means and product features in front of them. Also, they are more likely to have fear of missing out. Meanwhile, Gen Z, once they feel like it's an ad, become dissatisfied. Overall, it is not pure advertising anymore; it's about feelings and emotions.

- Gen Z reacts and engages faster on social media, while Millennials tend to trust more traditional advertising.

7. Question: What are the industries that mostly use UGC?

Most of the experts said that it depends on who we are targeting, whether it is business-to-business or business-to-customer. However, user-generated content is mainly used in business-to-customer. If we talk about industries, it doesn't matter, because all industries use user-generated content. Another expert added that in the food and beverage category, you can trigger it much easier if you have an experiential aspect, as it is all about how the consumer feels about the product.

- User-generated content is mostly used in business-to-customer marketing, but the industry doesn't really matter because almost all industries use it now—except luxury brands.

8. Question: What is the best platform to use UGC to affect the purchasing decisions of Gen Z? And why?

All experts said that user-generated content has a similar effect on Gen Z across both Instagram and TikTok. However, TikTok is slightly more viral. The difference appears in the buyer persona, as the persona on Instagram is more luxury-oriented, professional, and higher in class compared to TikTok.

- User-generated content works well on both Instagram and TikTok for Gen Z, but TikTok is more popular. The difference is in the audience: Instagram users prefer a more polished and premium style, while TikTok users are more spontaneous and into trends.

9. Question: Do you think FOMO affects purchase decisions among Gen Z? And why?

All experts said that fear of missing out affects Gen Z a lot because it plays on their behavior to avoid missing out on the experience. It also gives them a feeling of value, which is something Gen Z is looking for. Another expert said that Gen Z will not interact with the product because of fear of missing out, but they will go and buy the product because they feel that the product is made specifically for them.

- Fear of missing out strongly affects Gen Z because they don't want to miss out on One of the experts said that it depends on the type of fear of missing out that you want to create. If it's temporary fear of missing out, you have to focus on linking between them. However, if it's permanent fear of missing out, you don't have to link between them. Another expert didn't agree,

because the company doesn't depend on user-generated content to create fear of missing out. Experiences. It makes them feel included and special, and it also increases sales.

10. Question: Is the impact of FOMO on companies a temporary or permanent effect?

Some of the experts said that it can be temporary or permanent, depending on what the marketer wants. Additionally, another expert mentioned that the company might use fear of missing out as a strategy and work on it with each product they produce to create hype and make it go viral, but it can't be used for the same product in the long term. Moreover, another one said that it depends on the customer's experience: if they were satisfied with the experience, they might buy again and even develop loyalty. However, if the experience made the customer unsatisfied, the customer won't come back no matter how good the campaigns are.

- The difference between a temporary and permanent effect comes from the product quality and how the customer is treated throughout the purchase. The company can use fear of missing out as a strategy, but it is usually temporary.

11. Questions: Do you think that there is a relation between UGC and FOMO? Or not?

One of the experts said that if there is fear of missing out, most of the time there is no user generated content, because user-generated content is based on variety, which doesn't trigger fear in the audience. However, influencer content can trigger fear of missing out, as it often comes from one person whose influence reaches and affects many others. For temporary fear of missing out, the marketer focuses on user-generated content to boost sales in a specific time period. But for permanent fear of missing out, the marketer doesn't focus on user-generated content to make it rare and unique, as luxury brands do. Another expert didn't agree, because the company doesn't wait until user-generated content creates hype and becomes viral by itself. Fear of missing out depends more on popular influencers' content. Another expert said that the main target is not about triggering fear of missing out; it may or may not be triggered. Another one said that there must be a connection because the goal of buying the product is always developed to fit Gen Z.

- Yes, user-generated content increases fear of missing out because when people see others like them trying a product, they don't want to miss it. User-generated content builds trust, and fear of missing out pushes people to buy faster before the chance is gone.

12. Questions: Do you think there are a lot of people who link both UGC and FOMO together?

All the experts said that it's a rare topic and no one talks about it, even though it's one of the most important phenomena in marketing. There is limited academic research on this topic, and we hope your work will contribute valuable insights to the field. Another one added that user-generated content and fear of missing out complement each other across different types of marketing.

- Yes, it's important to connect both because they affect each other. But there isn't much research on combining the two, especially in Egypt.

13. Questions: What is the importance of connecting UGC and FOMO in the future?

One of the experts said that it depends on the type of fear of missing out that you want to create. If it's temporary fear of missing out, you have to focus on linking between them. However, if it's a permanent fear of missing out, you don't have to link between them. Another expert didn't agree, because the company doesn't depend on user-generated content to create fear of missing out.

- Yes, the connection between them will be important, because both user generated content and fear of missing out influence consumer behavior in different but complementary ways. User-generated content makes customers trust the product more, while fear of missing out increases their motivation to buy. When brands combine both, they can build trust and encourage more purchases.

6. Research Problem

User-generated content (UGC) has become a powerful force in shaping the purchasing experience, especially for Gen Z. When consumers independently create and share their own experiences with the product/service, it engages more potential buyers, increases trust, generates a sense of fear of missing out (FOMO), and influence on the online purchasing design. Online purchase is divided into two stages: purchase intention and actual purchase. The focus of this research will be on purchase intentions. However, existing studies often analyze UGC or FOMO separately. Therefore, this study looks at the effect of user-generated content and fear of missing out on Gen Z's trust and online purchase intention in urban Egypt. This study specifically is applied on Instagram and TikTok platforms.

7. Research Questions

Questions:

- Q1: How does user-generated content (UGC) affect online purchase intention among Gen Z users?
- Q2: To what extent does fear of missing out (FOMO) influence on online purchase intention among Gen Z users?
- Q3: What effect does user-generated content (UGC) have on trust among Gen Z users?
- Q4: To what extent does fear of missing out (FOMO) influence trust among Gen Z users?
- Q5: How does trust affect online purchase intention among Gen Z users?
- Q6: To what extent do social media platforms (Instagram / TikTok) moderate the relationship between user-generated content (UGC) and trust among Gen Z users?

- Q7: To what extent do social media platforms (Instagram / TikTok) moderate the relationship between fear of missing out (FOMO) and trust among Gen Z users?

8. Research Objective

Objective:

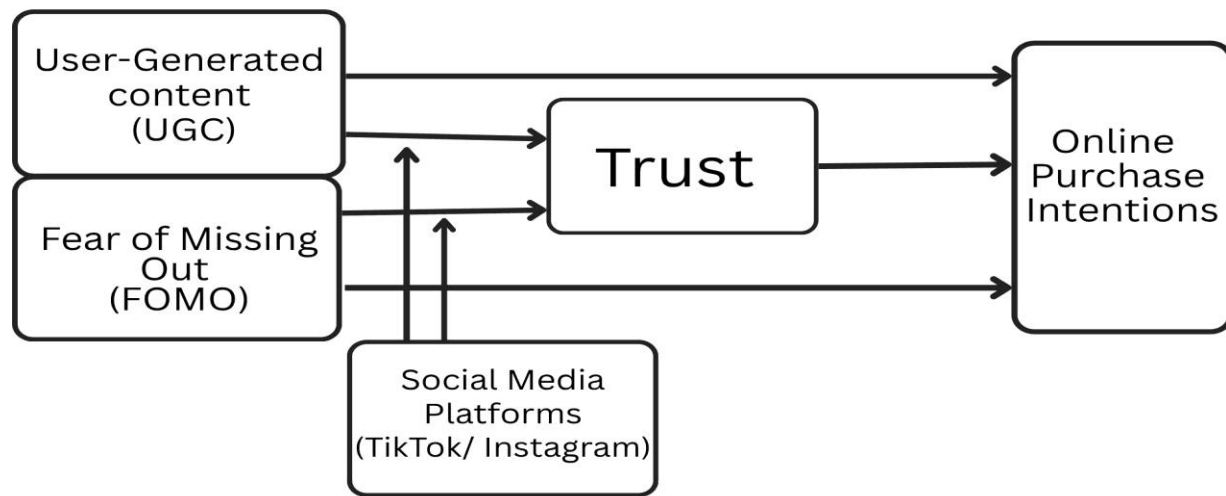
- O1: To find out the effect of user-generated content (UGC) on online purchase intention among Gen Z users.
- O2: To find out the effect of fear of missing out (FOMO) on online purchase intention among Gen Z users.
- O3: To find out the effect of user-generated content (UGC) on trust on Gen Z users.
- O4: To find out the effect of fear of missing out (FOMO) on trust on Gen Z users.
- O5: To examine the effect of trust on online purchase intention among Gen Z users.
- O6: To test the moderating effect of social media platforms (Instagram / TikTok) in the relationship between user-generated content (UGC) and trust.
- O7: To test the moderating effect of social media platforms (Instagram / TikTok) on the relationship between fear of missing out (FOMO) and trust.

9. Research Hypotheses

Hypotheses:

- H1: There is a significant relationship between user-generated content (UGC) and online purchase intentions.
- H2: There is a significant relationship between fear of missing out (FOMO) and online purchase intentions.
- H3: There is a significant positive relationship between user-generated content (UGC) and trust.
- H4: There is a significant positive relationship between fear of missing out (FOMO) and trust.
- H5: There is a significant positive relationship between trust and online purchase intentions.
- H6: Social media platforms (Instagram/TikTok) significantly moderate the relationship between user-generated content (UGC) and trust.
- H7: Social media platforms (Instagram/TikTok) significantly moderate the relationship between fear of missing out (FOMO) and trust.

10. Research Conceptual Model



11. Research Importance

This research is important because social media has become a main source of information for Generation Z. Many of them rely on user-generated content (UGC) such as reviews, comments, and posts. The study investigates how UGC and the fear of missing out (FOMO) influence trust, which in turn affects online purchase intention directly. Although previous research has studied social media and online behavior, few studies have explored the combined effect of UGC and FOMO on trust specifically for Generation Z, and even fewer have compared platforms like Instagram and TikTok. From a practical perspective, this research provides actionable insights for marketers and businesses by highlighting how UGC and FOMO can be strategically used to influence trust among Generation Z consumers, as well as identifying which types of content and platform features are more effective in shaping consumer perceptions and encouraging engagement. Understanding these relationships can help marketers and brands design more effective campaigns, build trust, and increase purchase intentions among Gen Z users.

12. Research Design and Methodology

12.1 Research Design

This research is conclusive causal because it studies the effect of UGC, FOMO, and social media platforms (TikTok and Instagram) on trust and online purchases. It focuses on understanding how these factors influence consumer behavior, not just describing what is happening. Also, this research is cross-sectional because data is collected one time using a survey.

12.2 Research Methodology

This research uses a quantitative method because it relies on numerical data to measure the relationships between variables. The logic of the research is deductive, as it is based on existing theories and tests them in this study. The data used is primary data, collected directly from respondents using a survey. The survey is divided into two parts, one focusing on TikTok users and the other on Instagram users, to compare how each platform affects trust and online purchase behavior.

13. Population and Sampling

13.1 Population

The study population consisted of early youth, teenagers, and university students, especially those between the ages of 18 and 24. This target group was selected because they use social media more frequently, engage more actively with advertising content, and are more likely to trust user-generated content (UGC), which may influence their purchase decisions.

According to DataReportal (2025), the number of Instagram users in Egypt aged 18–24 was approximately 8.2 million users, while the number of TikTok users in the same age group was approximately 13.9 million users, resulting in an estimated population size of approximately 22.1 million individuals.

13.2 Sampling

According to the Sekaran Sample Size Table, since the population exceeded one million, it was treated as an infinite population, and the required sample size was approximately 384 respondents. Since the aim of this research was to compare how Instagram and TikTok influence Gen Z's online purchase behaviour, non-probability sampling, specifically judgemental sampling, was used to select active users of both platforms.

The sample was equally divided between Instagram and TikTok users, with 50% representing Instagram users and 50% representing TikTok users. A total of 400 responses were collected, including 200 questionnaires from Instagram users and 200 questionnaires from TikTok users.

14. Data Collection Method

This study aimed to make a clear comparison between the two platforms by collecting responses equally from Instagram users (50%) and TikTok users (50%), as both platforms are widely used by Gen Z. The survey was designed using Google Forms because it is easy to use and familiar to this age group. Then share the link of the questioner online through WhatsApp. This method is used to easily reach our target.

15. Measurements and Scaling of The Questionnaire

Hypotheses	Variables	Measurements	Scale	Source
H1: There is a significant relationship between user-generated content (UGC) and online purchase intentions.	IV: UGC	1. UGC on Instagram is unbiased. 2. UGC helps in reducing my uncertainty about the brand and product. 3. UGC on Instagram enables me to purchase products that meet my needs and criteria. 4. I tend to choose UGC that is created by people who have similar taste with me. 5. UGC makes information about the brand or products immediately accessible.	Interval Scale(5-point Likert)	(Aurellia,2020)
	DV: Purchase Intention	1. I intend to buy a product after seeing UGC about it on Instagram/TikTok. 2. I would complete an online purchase after reading positive user reviews. 3. I search for more product information after seeing UGC on social media. 4. I am likely to purchase a product that many users are reviewing online. 5. Based on user reviews, I feel at ease making purchases from a platform I trust.		(Pramesti & Alversia, 2024), (Demba et al., 2019),(Wijaya et al., 2024), (Yen et al., 2021) ,(Gefen et al., 2003)
H2: There is a significant relationship between Fear of missing out (FOMO) and online purchase intentions.	IV: Fear of missing out (FOMO)	1. I feel like I might be missing out when I don't check social media to see what others are saying about this product.		(Habib and Almamy ,2025) (Lee; and Wut,Wan, 2025) (Çetinkaya and

		2. I feel pressured to buy the product before it's too late. 3. I feel uneasy seeing others talk about this product while I haven't tried it yet. 4. I would fear that those people who have purchased this product would have more rewarding experiences than me. 5. Being anxious about not keeping up with the latest trends.		Yıldız, 2025)
H3: There is a significant positive relationship between user-generated content (UGC) and trust.	DV:Trust	1. I trust the product advice shared by users reviews. 2. Users opinions are more trustworthy than traditional media. 3. The users content is reliable and honest.		(Cantinho , 2025) (Rahman , 2024)
H4: There is a significant positive relationship between fear of missing out (FOMO) and trust.	mentioned in the above	mentioned in the above.		mentioned in the above.
H5: There is a significant positive relationship between trust and online purchase intentions.	mentioned in the above	mentioned in the above.		mentioned in the above.
H6: Social media Platforms (Instagram /TikTok) significantly moderate the relationship between user-generated content (UGC) and trust.	Moderator: TikTok and Instagram platforms	Which platform influences your purchase decisions more? ☐ Instagram ☐ TikTok	Nominal	
H7: Social media platforms (Instagram /TikTok) significantly moderate the relationship between fear of missing out (FOMO) and trust.	mentioned in the above	mentioned in the above.	mentioned in the above.	mentioned in the above.

16. Data Analysis

The data entered through the SPSS program. We used the proper statistical methods. Techniques were applied in line with the research sample, objectives, and hypotheses. We used descriptive statistics, such as frequencies and percentages, to summaries the data. Additionally, inferential statistics were used to examine relationships and draw conclusions. This method made sure that the data that was collected was understood correctly.

17. Research Limitations

This study has some limitations. The results might not be applicable to everyone because the sample size was limited to the people in urban Egypt only on people aged 18 to 24. This age group was selected as the main focus of the study due to limitations in data availability.

In addition, the data was collected using an online survey, which may have resulted in some biased responses. Furthermore, the study adopted a cross-sectional design and was conducted over a short period of time due to time constraints, which may have affected the accuracy of the results.

18. Research Findings and Hypotheses Testing

18.1. Descriptive Statistics

18.1.1 The Demographics

Instagram Responses (N=200)

Variable	Category	Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Age Group	21-24	135	67.5%	67.5%	67.5%
	18-20	65	32.5%	32.5%	100.0%
	Total	200	100.0%	100.0%	
Gender	Female	105	52.5%	52.5%	52.5%
	Male	95	47.5%	47.5%	100.0%
	Total	200	100.0%	100.0%	

- Most of the respondents were young adults aged **21–24**, representing **(67.5%)** of the sample. The sample was slightly female-dominated **(52.5%)**, and the majority of respondents were Instagram users **(68.5%)**.

TikTok Responses (N=200)

Variable	Category	Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Age Group	21-24	138	69.0%	69.0%	69.0%
	18-20	62	31.0%	31.0%	100.0%
	Total	200	100.0%	100.0%	
Gender	Male	113	56.5%	56.5%	56.5%
	Female	87	43.5%	43.5%	100.0%
	Total	200	100.0%	100.0%	

- Most of the respondents were young adults aged **21–24**, accounting for 69.0% of the sample. The sample was predominantly male (**56.5%**), while Instagram users represented the larger proportion of respondents (**62.5%**) compared to TikTok users.

18.1.2 Introductory Questions

Which platform influences your purchase decisions more.

Instagram Responses (N=200)

Variable	Category	Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Platform	Instagram	137	68.5%	68.5%	68.5%
	TikTok	63	31.5%	31.5%	100.0%
	Total	200	100.0%	100.0%	

- Most of the respondents were Instagram users, representing 68.5% of the sample, while TikTok users accounted for 31.5%. This indicated that Instagram was the dominant platform among respondents in the Instagram sample.

TikTok Responses (N=200)

Variable	Category	Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Platform	Instagram	125	62.5%	62.5%	62.5%
	TikTok	75	37.5%	37.5%	100.0%
	Total	200	100.0%	100.0%	

- Most of the respondents were Instagram users, accounting for 62.5% of the sample, whereas TikTok users represented 37.5%. This suggested that Instagram remained the more frequently used platform even within the TikTok sample.

18.1.3 User-generated content (UGC)

User generated content Instagram is unbiased.					
		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	Strongly disagree	17	8.5	8.5	8.5
	Disagree	41	20.5	20.5	29.0
	Neutral	100	50.0	50.0	79.0
	Agree	32	16.0	16.0	95.0
	Strongly agree	10	5.0	5.0	100.0
	Total	200	100.0	100.0	

- The **highest percentage** was **(Neutral) 50%**, indicating that many respondents neither agreed nor disagreed that Instagram user-generated content is unbiased.
- The **lowest percentage** was **(Strongly agree) 5%**, indicating that only a small number of participants strongly believed that Instagram user-generated content is unbiased.

User generated content TikTok is unbiased.					
		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	Strongly disagree	24	12.0	12.0	12.0
	Disagree	39	19.5	19.5	31.5
	Neutral	82	41.0	41.0	72.5
	Agree	41	20.5	20.5	93.0
	Strongly agree	14	7.0	7.0	100.0
	Total	200	100.0	100.0	

- The **highest percentage** was **(Neutral) 41.0%**, indicating that the majority of participants were neutral regarding the lack of bias in TikTok user-generated content.
- The **lowest percentage** was **(Strongly agree) 7.0%**, indicating that very few participants strongly believe that this content is unbiased.

User generated content helps in reducing my uncertainty about the brand and product. (Instagram)					
		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	Strongly disagree	12	6.0	6.0	6.0
	Disagree	27	13.5	13.5	19.5
	Neutral	55	27.5	27.5	47.0
	Agree	85	42.5	42.5	89.5
	Strongly agree	21	10.5	10.5	100.0
	Total	200	100.0	100.0	

- The **highest percentage** was (**Agree**) **42.5%**, indicating that many respondents believe that user-generated content helps reduce uncertainty about brands and products.
- The **lowest percentage** was (**Strongly disagree**) **6%**, indicating that only a small number of participants believed that user-generated content does not reduce uncertainty about brands and products.

User generated content helps in reducing my uncertainty about the brand and product. (TikTOK)					
		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	Strongly disagree	14	7.0	7.0	7.0
	Disagree	22	11.0	11.0	18.0
	Neutral	54	27.0	27.0	45.0
	Agree	85	42.5	42.5	87.5
	Strongly agree	25	12.5	12.5	100.0
	Total	200	100.0	100.0	

- The **highest percentage** was (**Agree**) **42.5%**, indicating that the majority of participants agree that user-generated content helps reduce their uncertainty about brands and products.
- The **lowest percentage** was (**Strongly disagree**) **7.0%**, indicating that a very small segment of participants feels that user-generated content does not help in reducing uncertainty.

User generated content on Instagram enables me to purchase products that meet my needs and criteria.					
		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	Strongly disagree	15	7.5	7.5	7.5
	Disagree	21	10.5	10.5	18.0
	Neutral	58	29.0	29.0	47.0
	Agree	86	43.0	43.0	90.0
	Strongly agree	20	10.0	10.0	100.0
	Total	200	100.0	100.0	

- The **highest percentage** was (**Agree**) **43%**, indicating that many respondents believe that Instagram user-generated content enables them to purchase products that meet their needs and criteria.
- The **lowest percentage** was (**Strongly disagree**) **7.5%**, indicating that only a small number of participants believed that Instagram user-generated content does not help them purchase suitable products.

User generated content on TikTok enables me to purchase products that meet my needs and criteria.					
		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	Strongly disagree	19	9.5	9.5	9.5
	Disagree	28	14.0	14.0	23.5
	Neutral	59	29.5	29.5	53.0
	Agree	74	37.0	37.0	90.0
	Strongly agree	20	10.0	10.0	100.0
	Total	200	100.0	100.0	

- The **highest percentage** was (**Agree**) **37.0%**, indicating that the majority of participants agree that TikTok UGC helps them find products that fit their specific needs.
- The **lowest percentage** was (**Strongly disagree**) **9.5%**, indicating that the lowest percentage of participants who feel strongly that UGC does not enable them to meet their purchase criteria.

User generated content makes information about the brand or products immediately accessible.(Instagram)					
		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	Strongly disagree	17	8.5	8.5	8.5
	Disagree	18	9.0	9.0	17.5
	Neutral	47	23.5	23.5	41.0
	Agree	92	46.0	46.0	87.0
	Strongly agree	26	13.0	13.0	100.0
	Total	200	100.0	100.0	

- The **highest percentage** was (**Agree**) **46%**, indicating that most respondents believed that user-generated content makes information about the brand or products immediately accessible.
- The **lowest percentage** was (**Strongly disagree**) **8.5%**, suggesting that only a small number of participants strongly believed that user-generated content does not make information about the brand or products immediately accessible.

User generated content makes information about the brand or products immediately accessible. (TikTok)					
		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	Strongly disagree	11	5.5	5.5	5.5
	Disagree	10	5.0	5.0	10.5
	Neutral	57	28.5	28.5	39.0
	Agree	90	45.0	45.0	84.0
	Strongly agree	32	16.0	16.0	100.0
	Total	200	100.0	100.0	

- The **highest percentage** was (**Agree**) **45.0%**, indicating that the largest portion of participants agree that user-generated content provides immediate accessibility to brand information.
- The **lowest percentage** was (**Disagree**) **5.0%**, indicating that the lowest percentage of participants who feel that the information is not immediately accessible.

18.1.4 Trust

I trust the product advice shared by users. (Instagram)					
		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	Strongly disagree	20	10.0	10.0	10.0
	Disagree	36	18.0	18.0	28.0
	Neutral	94	47.0	47.0	75.0
	Agree	36	18.0	18.0	93.0
	Strongly agree	14	7.0	7.0	100.0
	Total	200	100.0	100.0	

- The **highest percentage** was **(Neutral) 47.0%**, indicating that a large portion of respondents neither agreed nor disagreed that they trust product advice shared by users.
- The **lowest percentage** was **(Strongly agree) 7.0%**, indicating that only a small number of participants firmly believe in the trustworthiness of user-shared product advice.

I trust the product advice shared by users. (TikTok)					
		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	Strongly disagree	13	6.5	6.5	6.5
	Disagree	23	11.5	11.5	18.0
	Neutral	99	49.5	49.5	67.5
	Agree	49	24.5	24.5	92.0
	Strongly agree	16	8.0	8.0	100.0
	Total	200	100.0	100.0	

- The **highest percentage** was **(Neutral) 49.5%**, indicating that nearly half of the participants maintain a neutral stance regarding their trust in product advice shared by other users.
- The **lowest percentage** was **(Strongly disagree) 6.5%**, indicating that only a small segment of participants strongly distrust user-shared product advice.

Users opinions are more trustworthy than traditional media (Instagram)					
		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	Strongly disagree	18	9.0	9.0	9.0
	Disagree	22	11.0	11.0	20.0
	Neutral	51	25.5	25.5	45.5
	Agree	68	34.0	34.0	79.5
	Strongly agree	41	20.5	20.5	100.0
	Total	200	100.0	100.0	

- The **highest percentage** was (**Agree**) **34.0%**, indicating that many respondents believe user opinions are more trustworthy than traditional media.
- The **lowest percentage** was (**Strongly disagree**) **9.0%**, indicating that only a few participants completely disagree with the idea that user opinions carry more weight than traditional media.

Users opinions are more trustworthy than traditional media (TikTok)					
		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	Strongly disagree	20	10.0	10.0	10.0
	Disagree	17	8.5	8.5	18.5
	Neutral	51	25.5	25.5	44.0
	Agree	75	37.5	37.5	81.5
	Strongly agree	37	18.5	18.5	100.0
	Total	200	100.0	100.0	

- The **highest percentage** was (**Agree**) **37.5%**, indicating that the majority of participants agree that user opinions are more trustworthy than traditional media.
- The **lowest percentage** was (**Disagree**) **8.5%**, indicating that the smallest group of participants who do not find user opinions more trustworthy than traditional media.

The users content is reliable and honest. (Instagram)					
		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	Strongly disagree	17	8.5	8.5	8.5
	Disagree	43	21.5	21.5	30.0
	Neutral	95	47.5	47.5	77.5
	Agree	40	20.0	20.0	97.5
	Strongly agree	5	2.5	2.5	100.0
	Total	200	100.0	100.0	

- The **highest percentage** was **(Neutral) 47.5%**, indicating that nearly half of the respondents are undecided on whether user content is reliable and honest.
- The **lowest percentage** was **(Strongly agree) 2.5%**, indicating that a very minimal number of participants strongly believe in the complete honesty and reliability of user content.

The users content is reliable and honest. (TikTok)					
		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	Strongly disagree	21	10.5	10.5	10.5
	Disagree	31	15.5	15.5	26.0
	Neutral	97	48.5	48.5	74.5
	Agree	35	17.5	17.5	92.0
	Strongly agree	16	8.0	8.0	100.0
	Total	200	100.0	100.0	

- The **highest percentage** was **(Neutral) 48.5%**, indicating that the majority of participants are neutral about the reliability and honesty of user content.
- The **lowest percentage** was **(Strongly agree) 8.0%**, indicating that a very small portion of participants are completely certain that user content is reliable and honest.

18.1.5 Fear Of Missing Out (FOMO)

I feel like I might be missing out when I don't check social media to see what others are saying about this product. (Instagram)					
		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	Strongly disagree	22	11.0	11.0	11.0
	Disagree	35	17.5	17.5	28.5
	Neutral	54	27.0	27.0	55.5
	Agree	63	31.5	31.5	87.0
	Strongly agree	26	13.0	13.0	100.0
	Total	200	100.0	100.0	

- The **highest percentage** was (**Agree**) **31.5%**, indicating that many respondents feel they might be missing out when they don't check social media to see what others are saying about a product.
- The **lowest percentage** was (**Strongly disagree**) **11.0%**, indicating that only a small number of participants firmly reject the feeling of missing out in this context.

I feel like I might be missing out when I don't check social media to see what others are saying about this product. (TikTok)					
		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	Strongly disagree	24	12.0	12.0	12.0
	Disagree	34	17.0	17.0	29.0
	Neutral	53	26.5	26.5	55.5
	Agree	62	31.0	31.0	86.5
	Strongly agree	27	13.5	13.5	100.0
	Total	200	100.0	100.0	

- The **highest percentage** was (**Agree**) **31.0%**, indicating that the largest segment of participants experiences a sense of missing out when they do not actively monitor social media discussions regarding the product.
- The **lowest percentage** was (**Strongly disagree**) **12.0%**, indicating that only a very small percentage of participants are completely unaffected by social media absence in relation to the product.

I feel pressured to buy the product before it's too late. (Instagram)					
		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	Strongly disagree	20	10.0	10.0	10.0
	Disagree	51	25.5	25.5	35.5
	Neutral	62	31.0	31.0	66.5
	Agree	50	25.0	25.0	91.5
	Strongly agree	17	8.5	8.5	100.0
	Total	200	100.0	100.0	

- The **highest percentage** was **(Neutral) 31.0%**, indicating that a significant portion of respondents neither feel pressured nor unpressured to buy the product before it is too late.
- The **lowest percentage** was **(Strongly agree) 8.5%**, indicating that very few participants feel intense pressure to make a purchase quickly.

I feel pressured to buy the product before it's too late. (TikTok)					
		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	Strongly disagree	34	17.0	17.0	17.0
	Disagree	65	32.5	32.5	49.5
	Neutral	50	25.0	25.0	74.5
	Agree	42	21.0	21.0	95.5
	Strongly agree	9	4.5	4.5	100.0
	Total	200	100.0	100.0	

- The **highest percentage** was **(Disagree) 32.5%**, indicating that the largest portion of respondents does not feel immediate, direct time-based pressure to purchase the product.
- The **lowest percentage** was **(Strongly agree) 4.5%**, indicating that only an extremely small minority of consumers feel intense, urgent pressure to buy the product before it is too late.

I feel uneasy seeing others talk about this product while I haven't tried it yet. (Instagram)					
		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	Strongly disagree	34	17.0	17.0	17.0
	Disagree	54	27.0	27.0	44.0
	Neutral	62	31.0	31.0	75.0
	Agree	40	20.0	20.0	95.0
	Strongly agree	10	5.0	5.0	100.0
	Total	200	100.0	100.0	

- The **highest percentage** was **(Neutral) 31.0%**, indicating that many participants are indifferent or undecided about feeling uneasy when others talk about a product they haven't tried yet.
- The **lowest percentage** was **(Strongly agree) 5.0%**, indicating that only a tiny fraction of respondents experience strong unease in this situation.

I feel uneasy seeing others talk about this product while I haven't tried it yet. (TikTok)					
		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	Strongly disagree	37	18.5	18.5	18.5
	Disagree	56	28.0	28.0	46.5
	Neutral	47	23.5	23.5	70.0
	Agree	44	22.0	22.0	92.0
	Strongly agree	16	8.0	8.0	100.0
	Total	200	100.0	100.0	

- The **highest percentage** was **(Disagree) 28.0%**, indicating that a major portion of the participants do not feel uncomfortable or uneasy when observing others talk about a product they have not tried.
- The **lowest percentage** was **(Strongly agree) 8.0%**, indicating that the minimal percentage of respondents who experience strong negative emotional uneasiness in response to peer discussions of the untried product.

I would fear that those people who have purchased this product would have more rewarding experiences than me. (Instagram)					
		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	Strongly disagree	19	9.5	9.5	9.5
	Disagree	44	22.0	22.0	31.5
	Neutral	70	35.0	35.0	66.5
	Agree	55	27.5	27.5	94.0
	Strongly agree	12	6.0	6.0	100.0
	Total	200	100.0	100.0	

- The **highest percentage** was **(Neutral) 35.0%**, indicating that a large number of respondents are unsure if others who purchased the product are having more rewarding experiences than them.
- The **lowest percentage** was **(Strongly agree) 6.0%**, indicating that only a small group of participants strongly fear that they are missing out on better experiences compared to other buyers.

I would fear that those people who have purchased this product would have more rewarding experiences than me. (TikTok)					
		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	Strongly disagree	31	15.5	15.5	15.5
	Disagree	50	25.0	25.0	40.5
	Neutral	50	25.0	25.0	65.5
	Agree	55	27.5	27.5	93.0
	Strongly agree	14	7.0	7.0	100.0
	Total	200	100.0	100.0	

- The **highest percentage** was **(Agree) 27.5%**, indicating that the largest segment of participants has an underlying fear that others are enjoying a more rewarding experience by adopting the product first.
- The **lowest percentage** was **(Strongly agree) 7.0%**, indicating that only a small portion strongly experiences this severe form of social anxiety.

Being anxious about not keeping up with the latest trends. (Instagram)					
		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	Strongly disagree	36	18.0	18.0	18.0
	Disagree	49	24.5	24.5	42.5
	Neutral	57	28.5	28.5	71.0
	Agree	45	22.5	22.5	93.5
	Strongly agree	13	6.5	6.5	100.0
	Total	200	100.0	100.0	

- The **highest percentage** was **(Neutral) 28.5%**, indicating that many respondents are neutral regarding their anxiety about keeping up with the latest trends.
- The **lowest percentage** was **(Strongly agree) 6.5%**, indicating that only a minimal number of participants feel strong anxiety about staying current with trends.

Being anxious about not keeping up with the latest trends. (TikTok)					
		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	Strongly disagree	39	19.5	19.5	19.5
	Disagree	41	20.5	20.5	40.0
	Neutral	63	31.5	31.5	71.5
	Agree	46	23.0	23.0	94.5
	Strongly agree	11	5.5	5.5	100.0
	Total	200	100.0	100.0	

- The **highest percentage** was **(Neutral) 31.5%**, indicating that a majority of the sample remains somewhat moderate or undecided about whether keeping up with the latest trends induces personal anxiety.
- The **lowest percentage** was **(Strongly agree) 5.5%**, indicating that very few participants experience severe, outright anxiety regarding their ability to keep up with incoming market trends.

18.1.6 Online Purchases

I intend to buy a product after seeing UGC about it on Instagram.					
		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	Strongly disagree	16	8.0	8.0	8.0
	Disagree	28	14.0	14.0	22.0
	Neutral	72	36.0	36.0	58.0
	Agree	76	38.0	38.0	96.0
	Strongly agree	8	4.0	4.0	100.0
	Total	200	100.0	100.0	

- The **highest percentage** was (**Agree**) **38.0%**, indicating that a significant portion of respondents intend to buy a product after seeing user-generated content (UGC) on Instagram.
- The **lowest percentage** was (**Strongly agree**) **4.0%**, indicating that only a minimal number of participants have a very firm intention to purchase immediately after encountering

I intend to buy a product after seeing UGC about it on TikTok					
		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	Strongly disagree	17	8.5	8.5	8.5
	Disagree	27	13.5	13.5	22.0
	Neutral	70	35.0	35.0	57.0
	Agree	74	37.0	37.0	94.0
	Strongly agree	12	6.0	6.0	100.0
	Total	200	100.0	100.0	

- The **highest percentage** was (**Agree**) **37.0%**, indicating that the majority of participants agree with the statement that they intend to buy a product after seeing User Generated Content about it on TikTok.
- The **lowest percentage** was (**Strongly agree**) **6.0%**, indicating that the lowest percentage of participants who strongly support this purchasing intention.

I would complete an online purchase after reading positive user reviews. (instagram)					
		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	Strongly disagree	14	7.0	7.0	7.0
	Disagree	17	8.5	8.5	15.5
	Neutral	62	31.0	31.0	46.5
	Agree	80	40.0	40.0	86.5
	Strongly agree	27	13.5	13.5	100.0
	Total	200	100.0	100.0	

- The **highest percentage** was (**Agree**) **40.0%**, indicating that many respondents would finalize an online purchase after reading positive user reviews.
- The **lowest percentage** was (**Strongly disagree**) **7.0%**, indicating that very few participants completely dismiss the positive influence of reviews on their final purchase decision.

I would complete an online purchase after reading positive user reviews.					
		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	Strongly disagree	21	10.5	10.5	10.5
	Disagree	12	6.0	6.0	16.5
	Neutral	55	27.5	27.5	44.0
	Agree	84	42.0	42.0	86.0
	Strongly agree	28	14.0	14.0	100.0
	Total	200	100.0	100.0	

- The **highest percentage** was (**Agree**) **42.0%**, indicating that the majority of participants agree they would complete an online purchase after reading positive user reviews.
- The **lowest percentage** was (**Disagree**) **6.0%**, indicating that very few participants actively disagree with the positive impact of reviews.

I search for more product information after seeing UGC on social media. (Instagram)					
		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	Strongly disagree	16	8.0	8.0	8.0
	Disagree	18	9.0	9.0	17.0
	Neutral	40	20.0	20.0	37.0
	Agree	92	46.0	46.0	83.0
	Strongly agree	34	17.0	17.0	100.0
	Total	200	100.0	100.0	

- The **highest percentage** was (**Agree**) **46.0%**, indicating that nearly half of the respondents are motivated to search for more product information after seeing UGC on social media.
- The **lowest percentage** was (**Strongly disagree**) **8.0%**, indicating that only a small group of participants are not prompted to research further by social media content.

I search for more product information after seeing UGC on social media. (TikTok)					
		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	Strongly disagree	15	7.5	7.5	7.5
	Disagree	13	6.5	6.5	14.0
	Neutral	42	21.0	21.0	35.0
	Agree	87	43.5	43.5	78.5
	Strongly agree	43	21.5	21.5	100.0
	Total	200	100.0	100.0	

- The **highest percentage** was (**Agree**) **43.5%**, indicating that the majority of participants agree that they actively search for more product information after seeing UGC on social media platforms.
- The **lowest percentage** was (**Disagree**) **6.5%**, indicating that only a small minority of the participants do not seek further details.

I am likely to purchase a product that many users are reviewing online. (Instagram)					
		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	Strongly disagree	17	8.5	8.5	8.5
	Disagree	15	7.5	7.5	16.0
	Neutral	51	25.5	25.5	41.5
	Agree	83	41.5	41.5	83.0
	Strongly agree	34	17.0	17.0	100.0
	Total	200	100.0	100.0	

- The **highest percentage** was (**Agree**) **41.5%**, indicating that a large portion of users are likely to purchase products that many other users are reviewing online.
- The **lowest percentage** was (**Disagree**) **7.5%**, indicating that only a tiny fraction of respondents feel specifically unlikely to be influenced by the volume of online reviews.

I am likely to purchase a product that many users are reviewing online. (TikTok)					
		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	Strongly disagree	13	6.5	6.5	6.5
	Disagree	23	11.5	11.5	18.0
	Neutral	66	33.0	33.0	51.0
	Agree	63	31.5	31.5	82.5
	Strongly agree	35	17.5	17.5	100.0
	Total	200	100.0	100.0	

- The **highest percentage** was (**Neutral**) **33.0%**, indicating that a notable portion of the participants remain undecided or indifferent about whether a high volume of online reviews makes them more likely to purchase a product.
- The **lowest percentage** was (**Strongly disagree**) **6.5%**, indicating that very few participants completely dismiss the volume of reviews as a purchase factor.

Based on user reviews, I feel at ease making purchases from a platform I trust. (Instagram)					
		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	Strongly disagree	17	8.5	8.5	8.5
	Disagree	17	8.5	8.5	17.0
	Neutral	48	24.0	24.0	41.0
	Agree	77	38.5	38.5	79.5
	Strongly agree	41	20.5	20.5	100.0
	Total	200	100.0	100.0	

- The **highest percentage was (Agree) 38.5%**, indicating that many respondents feel comfortable making purchases from a trusted platform when supported by user reviews.
- The **lowest percentage was both (Strongly disagree and Disagree) 8.5% each**, indicating that a very low number of participants feel uneasy or skeptical about using reviews to shop on platforms they trust.

Based on user reviews, I feel at ease making purchases from a platform I trust. (TikTok)					
		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	Strongly disagree	15	7.5	7.5	7.5
	Disagree	17	8.5	8.5	16.0
	Neutral	44	22.0	22.0	38.0
	Agree	81	40.5	40.5	78.5
	Strongly agree	43	21.5	21.5	100.0
	Total	200	100.0	100.0	

- The **highest percentage was (Agree) 40.5%**, indicating that the majority of participants agree they feel at ease making purchases from a trusted platform when those purchases are supported by user reviews.
- The **lowest percentage was (Strongly disagree) 7.5%**, indicating that very few participants strongly disagree with this assertion.

18.2.1 Descriptive Statistics (Instagram)

	N	Minimum	Maximum	Mean	Std. Deviation
User generated content Instagram is unbiased.	200	1	5	2.89	.947
User generated content helps in reducing my uncertainty about the brand and product.	200	1	5	3.38	1.040
User generated content on Instagram enables me to purchase products that meet my needs and criteria.	200	1	5	3.38	1.049
I tend to choose user generated content that is created by people who have similar taste with me.	200	1	5	3.69	1.137
User generated content makes information about the brand or products immediately accessible.	200	1	5	3.46	1.097
I trust the product advice shared by users.	200	1	5	2.94	1.021
Users opinions are more trustworthy than traditional media.	200	1	5	3.46	1.194
The users content is reliable and honest.	200	1	5	2.87	.917
I feel like I might be missing out when I don't check social media to see what others are saying about this product.	200	1	5	3.18	1.194
I feel pressured to buy the product before it's too late.	200	1	5	2.97	1.118
I feel uneasy seeing others talk about this product	200	1	5	2.69	1.123

while I haven't tried it yet.					
I would fear that those people who have purchased this product would have more rewarding experiences than me.	200	1	5	2.99	1.058
Being anxious about not keeping up with the latest trends.	200	1	5	2.75	1.181
I intend to buy a product after seeing UGC about it on Instagram.	200	1	5	3.16	.990
I would complete an online purchase after reading positive user reviews.	200	1	5	3.45	1.055
I search for more product information after seeing UGC on social media.	200	1	5	3.55	1.120
I am likely to purchase a product that many users are reviewing online.	200	1	5	3.51	1.121
Based on user reviews, I feel at ease making purchases from a platform I trust.	200	1	5	3.54	1.160
Valid N (listwise)	200				

The descriptive statistics indicated that most statements related to Instagram user-generated content received moderate to high mean scores, reflecting positive perceptions among respondents. Participants reported that UGC helped reduce uncertainty about brands and products, assisted them in choosing suitable products, and was considered more trustworthy than traditional media. In addition, respondents showed moderate agreement that UGC positively influenced their purchase intentions through reviews and product information shared on Instagram. Overall, the findings suggested that Instagram user-generated content positively influenced consumers' trust, engagement, and purchasing behavior.

18.2.2 Descriptive Statistics (TikTok)

	N	Minimum	Maximum	Mean	Std. Deviation
User generated content TikTok is unbiased.	200	1	5	2.91	1.076
User generated content helps in reducing my uncertainty about the brand and product.	200	1	5	3.43	1.068
User generated content on TikTok enables me to purchase products that meet my needs and criteria.	200	1	5	3.24	1.113
I tend to choose user generated content that is created by people who have similar taste with me.	200	1	5	3.67	1.053
User generated content makes information about the brand or products immediately accessible.	200	1	5	3.61	.996
I trust the product advice shared by users.	200	1	5	3.16	.959
Users opinions are more trustworthy than traditional media.	200	1	5	3.46	1.181
The users content is reliable and honest.	200	1	5	2.97	1.037
I feel like I might be missing out when I don't check social media to see what others are saying about this product.	200	1	5	3.17	1.216
I feel pressured to buy the product before it's too late.	200	1	5	2.64	1.126
I feel uneasy seeing others talk about this product while I haven't tried it yet.	200	1	5	2.73	1.223
I would fear that those people who have purchased this product would have more rewarding experiences than me.	200	1	5	2.85	1.188
Being anxious about not keeping up with the latest trends.	200	1	5	2.74	1.173
I intend to buy a product after seeing UGC about it on TikTok.	200	1	5	3.19	1.028

I would complete an online purchase after reading positive user reviews.	200	1	5	3.43	1.132
I search for more product information after seeing UGC on social media.	200	1	5	3.65	1.115
I am likely to purchase a product that many users are reviewing online.	200	1	5	3.42	1.104
Based on user reviews, I feel at ease making purchases from a platform I trust.	200	1	5	3.60	1.139
Valid N (listwise)	200				

The descriptive statistics indicated that most statements related to TikTok user-generated content received moderate to high mean scores, reflecting positive perceptions among respondents. Participants reported that TikTok UGC helped reduce uncertainty about brands and products, enabled them to find products that matched their needs, and provided easily accessible information. Respondents also considered users' opinions more trustworthy than traditional media, while UGC moderately influenced their purchase intentions and product trust.

18.3 Hypotheses Testing

Correlations

		Ugc	Trust	FOMO	OPI
Ugc	Pearson Correlation	1	.641**	.406**	.694**
Trust	Pearson Correlation	.641**	1	.420**	.598**
FOMO	Pearson Correlation	.406**	.420**	1	.439**
OPI	Pearson Correlation	.694**	.598**	.439**	1
<i>Correlation is significant at the 0.01 level</i>					

The correlation analysis showed that all relationships between user-generated content, fear of missing out, trust, and online purchase intention were positive and statistically significant at the 0.01 level. Both user-generated content and fear of missing out, as independent variables, were positively related to trust and online purchase intention. User-generated content showed a strong relationship with trust and online purchase intention, while fear of missing out had a moderate positive relationship with both variables, indicating that greater exposure to user-generated content and higher fear of missing out increased consumers' trust and online purchase intention. Overall, the findings suggested that user-generated content and fear of missing out played important roles in influencing trust and enhancing online purchase intention.

19. Conclusion and Main recommendations

19.1 Conclusion

Q1: How does user-generated content (UGC) affect online purchase intention among Gen Z users?

UGC has a significant positive effect on the online purchase intentions of Gen Z users. When peers and fellow consumers share authentic reviews, comments, and posts about products on platforms like Instagram and TikTok, they reduce uncertainty and make product information immediately accessible. Gen Z users tend to rely on content created by people with similar tastes, which increases their confidence and motivates them to complete a purchase. Exposure to UGC consistently leads to higher willingness to buy, especially when the content reflects positive and relatable experiences.

Q2: To what extent does fear of missing out (FOMO) influence online purchase intention among Gen Z users?

FOMO has a notable and measurable influence on Gen Z's online purchase intentions. When Gen Z users feel that others are enjoying or benefiting from a product they have not yet tried, they experience anxiety and social pressure to act quickly. This urgency — driven by trends, limited-time offers, and the visible experiences of peers — increases the likelihood of making a purchase. The stronger the perceived social exclusion or missed opportunity, the higher the motivation to buy in order to keep up with others.

Q3: What effect does user-generated content (UGC) have on trust among Gen Z users?

UGC has a significant positive effect on trust among Gen Z users. Content generated by real users is perceived as more honest, unbiased, and credible compared to traditional advertising. When Gen Z consumers encounter reviews, testimonials, and shared experiences from other users, they view this content as reliable evidence of a product's quality. This perceived authenticity strengthens their trust in the brand and the product, making them more willing to engage and purchase.

Q4: To what extent does fear of missing out (FOMO) influence trust among Gen Z users?

FOMO also plays a role in shaping trust among Gen Z users, though its relationship with trust is more nuanced. When many people are seen using or praising a product, it creates a social proof effect that enhances the product's perceived credibility. The sense that a large number of peers have had rewarding experiences with a product can lead Gen Z users to trust it more. However, excessive or manipulative FOMO tactics may backfire, potentially undermining trust if perceived as inauthentic.

Q5: How does trust affect online purchase intention among Gen Z users?

Trust serves as a critical mediating factor between UGC/FOMO and online purchase intention. When Gen Z users trust a brand or product — whether influenced by peer reviews or social proof — they are significantly more likely to express a purchase intention and follow through with an actual transaction. Trust reduces perceived risk, increases comfort with online purchasing, and reinforces the decision to buy. Without trust, even compelling UGC or strong FOMO signals are unlikely to translate into purchases.

Q6: To what extent do social media platforms (Instagram/TikTok) moderate the relationship between UGC and trust among Gen Z users?

The social media platform used significantly moderates the relationship between UGC and trust. Instagram, known for its visually polished content and curated aesthetic, tends to generate trust through high-quality imagery and influencer posts. TikTok, on the other hand, thrives on raw, spontaneous, and relatable short-form video content, which Gen Z often finds more authentic. As a result, TikTok's UGC environment may foster stronger trust for certain product categories, while Instagram's UGC may be more effective for aspirational or lifestyle-oriented products. The platform's specific features and culture shape how UGC is received and trusted.

Q7: To what extent do social media platforms (Instagram/TikTok) moderate the relationship between FOMO and trust among Gen Z users?

Social media platforms also moderate the effect of FOMO on trust. TikTok's viral and trend-driven nature amplifies FOMO signals — trending sounds, hashtags, and challenges create a strong sense of urgency and social pressure that can enhance trust through widespread social proof. Instagram, with its Stories, Reels, and limited-time content features, similarly creates FOMO but in a more curated context. The intensity and form of FOMO differ between platforms, and this in turn affects how much trust is built through these social signals. Brands must therefore tailor their FOMO-based strategies to the specific mechanics of each platform.

19.2 Main recommendations

- ❖ Brands should prioritize user-generated content marketing strategies by encouraging customers to share authentic reviews, testimonials, and experiences, as Generation Z relies heavily on social media content more than traditional advertising.
- ❖ Brands should use fear of missing out in an ethical and realistic way through limited-time offers, exclusive products, and trending campaigns without damaging consumer trust.
- ❖ Building trust should remain a key strategic objective by maintaining transparency, high product quality, and continuous interaction with consumers through responding to reviews and feedback.
- ❖ Content strategies should be tailored to each platform, as Instagram users prefer polished and aspirational content, while TikTok users are more attracted to relatable and trend-driven content.
- ❖ Brands should engage Generation Z as active content creators through challenges, hashtags, contests, and collaborations to strengthen community engagement and trust.
- ❖ Combining user-generated content and fear of missing out in the same campaign can maximize effectiveness by creating both social proof and urgency, which positively influences purchase intention.
- ❖ Marketers should continuously study Generation Z behavior in Egypt to design campaigns that reflect local cultural values and online habits.

20. Suggestions for Further Research

- ❖ Future studies should expand the geographic scope beyond urban Egypt to include rural areas and other countries in the Middle East and North Africa region for broader comparisons.
- ❖ Researchers should include wider age groups to compare the effects of user-generated content and fear of missing out across different generations.
- ❖ Future studies should use diversified data collection methods such as interviews and focus groups in addition to online surveys to reduce response bias.
- ❖ Longitudinal research designs are recommended to examine how attitudes toward user-generated content, fear of missing out, trust, and purchase intention change over time.
- ❖ Future research should investigate additional social media platforms such as YouTube, Snapchat, and X to compare their influence on consumers.
- ❖ Researchers should examine actual purchasing behavior rather than focusing only on purchase intention.
- ❖ Future studies should compare different product categories, such as fashion, beauty, food, and electronics, to identify variations in consumer responses.
- ❖ Comparative studies across different cultural contexts are also recommended to examine how cultural differences influence the relationships between user-generated content, fear of missing out, trust, and purchase intention.

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Appendix

Faculty of Business Administration.

Major: Marketing.

The Effect of User-Generated Content and Fear of Missing Out on Gen Z's Trust and Online Purchases in Urban Egypt (Applied on Instagram and TikTok Platforms)

**Full Survey Questionnaire I Group Name: Catchy Minds
Supervisor: Dr. Ghada El-tazy**

Thank you for taking part in this survey.

I am a university student, and this questionnaire is part of my graduation project.

This survey aims to examine the effect of User-Generated Content (UGC) and Fear of Missing Out (FOMO) on Generation Z's trust and purchase intentions on social media platforms such as Instagram and TikTok.

Your responses will be kept confidential and used only for academic purposes. Participation is voluntary, and you may withdraw at any time.

This survey will take approximately 5-7 minutes to complete.

Which platform influences your purchase decisions more?

- TikTok
- Instagram
- Other

Please indicate your level of agreement with the following statements:

1 (Strongly Disagree) | 2 (Disagree) | 3 (Neutral) | 4 (Agree) | 5 (Strongly Agree)

UGC	1	2	3	4	5
1. User generated content Instagram / TikTok is unbiased.					
2. User generated content helps in reducing my uncertainty about the brand and product.					
3. User generated content on Instagram / TikTok enables me to purchase products that meet my needs and criteria.					
4. I tend to choose user generated content that is created by people who have similar taste with me.					
5. User generated content makes information about the brand or products immediately accessible.					

Please indicate your level of agreement with the following statements:

1 (Strongly Disagree) | 2 (Disagree) | 3 (Neutral) | 4 (Agree) | 5 (Strongly Agree)

Trust	1	2	3	4	5
6. I trust the product advice shared by users					
7. Users opinions are more trustworthy than traditional media.					
8. The users content is reliable and honest.					

Please indicate your level of agreement with the following statements:

1 (Strongly Disagree) | 2 (Disagree) | 3 (Neutral) | 4 (Agree) | 5 (Strongly Agree)

FOMO	1	2	3	4	5
9. I feel like I might be missing out when I don't check social media to see what others are saying about this product.					
10. I feel pressured to buy the product before it's too late.					
11. I feel uneasy seeing others talk about this product while I haven't tried it yet.					
12. I would fear that those people who have purchased this product would have more rewarding experiences than me.					
13. Being anxious about not keeping up with the latest trends.					

Please indicate your level of agreement with the following statements:

1 (Strongly Disagree) | 2 (Disagree) | 3 (Neutral) | 4 (Agree) | 5 (Strongly Agree)

Purchase intention	1	2	3	4	5
14. I intend to buy a product after seeing UGC about it on Instagram/TikTok.					
15. I would complete an online purchase after reading positive user reviews.					
16. I search for more product information after seeing UGC on social media.					
17. I am likely to purchase a product that many users are reviewing online.					
18. Based on user reviews, I feel at ease making purchases from a platform I trust.					

question	Choices
What is your age?	☐ 18 to less than 20 ☐ 20 to less than 24
What is your gender?	☐ Male ☐ Female

Thank you for your time and participation.

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